

Speculative Narratives Beyond Consensus Reality

Navigating the Senses from Wonder to Horror



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Organisers

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Keynote Speakers



Ana da Silveira Moura

University of Porto

Ana da Silveira Moura is an external collaborator at the University of Porto's Natural History and Science Museum. Her research focuses on speculative fiction, gender studies and contemporary narratives. She explores the intersection between feminism, futurism and science fiction in her research.

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***In Vino Veritas* – The Winepunk Universe as Collaborative Creative Backbone for Sustaining Shared Cultural Heritage**

When addressing the past we need to reconcile with, we usually associate this with the memories and experiences of minorities left outside the collective mainstream memory. But what if the forgotten past was national, affected majorities and minorities alike, and its origins are also left out of the collective mainstream memory? How do we overcome what we do not even remember existed, regardless of our identity group? The Kingdom of Portugal ceased to be a kingdom in 1910, a nonconsensual decision. On 19 January 1919, an insurrection broke out in the city of Porto, which declared the restoration of the monarchical regime, and launched a military offensive towards the capital of the Republic, Lisbon, in the south. This civil war lasted three weeks, was filled with peculiar episodes, and at present, almost no Portuguese is aware that it happened. Both sides, and the dictatorship that begun in 1926 in Portugal had (different) reasons to quietly keep it out of the national remembrance. In 2013, this historical episode provided the divergence point for the development of an alternative history universe, the Winepunk Universe. In the last decade, through a variety of creative and cultural outlets, the Winepunk Universe has allowed for the recovering of forgotten historical figures and episodes of several countries, working as a de facto collaborative creative backbone from literature to museology.





Camilla Grudova

Author

Camilla Grudova is an author of speculative and weird fiction. Her short stories explore strange and unsettling universes, combining Gothic elements with contemporary sensibilities. She is the author of 'The Doll's Alphabet' and 'Children of Paradise'.

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The Last Novel in the World: M. John Harrison's *The End of Everything* and the Death of Literature

Camilla Grudova will discuss M. John Harrison's latest novel, in which humans in a crumbling future Britain beachcomb for artefacts possibly belonging to an alien civilisation as a metaphor for how AI erodes meaning, humanity and art. As an author involved in the legal case against anthropic for stealing the work of thousands of authors, Grudova will bring in her personal experience and how she reads *The End of Everything* as a goodbye to literature, or a warning of a goodbye.



Michael Lundblad

University of Oslo

Michael Lundblad is a professor at the University of Oslo, where he researches animal studies, ecocriticism, and speculative fiction. His research examines representations of non-humans in literature and cinema.

Disanimality Down on the Factory Farm: When Disability, Illness, and Animality Meet in Don LePan's *Animals*

Comparisons between factory-farm animals, people with disabilities, and people killed in the Holocaust are a major site for what Lundblad has identified as *disanimality*, a feeling of discomfort that comes from overly simplistic comparisons between disabled people and animals. The suggestion that the suffering of animals in factory farms is comparable to the suffering of dehumanized or animalized people with disabilities is one that many disability advocates find abhorrent. It has also been used to animate dystopian texts that reverse the analogy, with disabled people raised and slaughtered as food in nightmarish near-future worlds, such as Don LePan's speculative fiction in his novel *Animals*. This talk takes LePan's novel as a primary site for exploring disanimality, questioning the implicit premise that all forms of meat-eating are necessarily ableist. Instead, the talk takes a posthumanist approach, focusing on biopolitical hierarchies in which certain forms of life in certain situated contexts become disposable, without necessarily needing to equate those various forms of life. The talk also provides an overview of Lundblad's new book, *Disanimality: When Disability, Illness, and Animality Meet* (Oxford University Press, 2026).



Nelson Zagalo

University of Aveiro

Nelson Zagalo is a professor at the University of Aveiro, specialized in interactive narratives, video games, and digital media. His work explores the speculative dimensions of contemporary media.

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Speculative AI Worlds: From “What If” to “As If”

Speculative fiction has always allowed us to imagine possible worlds, transforming hypothetical premises into narrative, sensory, and ethical experiences. Generative AI introduces a different condition: possible worlds can now be queried, negotiated, revised, and made responsive. The speculative gesture therefore moves from the authored “what if?” to a conversational “as if”, where imagination becomes an iterative space for testing consequences, meanings, and forms of human experience. This keynote examines how generative AI may be changing not only the production of speculative narratives, but the cultural practice of speculation itself. Traditional speculative fiction creates worlds that readers, viewers, or players imaginatively inhabit, while their ontological conditions remain stabilised by authorial design. AI-mediated speculative worlds, by contrast, can remain provisional, dialogic, and responsive. They need not appear as fully described settings or as narratives generated in advance. Instead, they may emerge as responsive speculative ecologies: characters, institutions, environments, archives, languages, or non-human systems through which users temporarily inhabit a transformed reality and discover its rules, tensions, and consequences through dialogue.

This shift does not make AI-mediated worlds more coherent or meaningful than literary ones. Rather, it changes the relation between hypothesis, imagination, and experience. Wonder no longer emerges only from encountering an imagined world, but from watching a hypothesis unfold into unexpected consequences within a responsive environment. At the same time, this responsiveness raises critical questions about authorship, coherence, opacity, and the loss of estrangement in systems designed to answer too quickly.

By moving from “what if?” to “as if”, generative AI invites us to rethink speculative fiction as a conversational practice: not simply the creation of alternative realities, but the temporary inhabitation of possible worlds through which we examine the assumptions, desires, fears, and limits of our own consensus reality.

Panellists

Adejumobi, Olufunmilayo. Vilniaus University of Applied Sciences, Lithuania
Globalisation and Mobility in Speculative Fiction: Imagined Borders, Displacement, and Transnational Identity

Speculative fiction has long provided a fertile space for interrogating experiences of mobility, displacement, and border-crossing beyond the constraints of consensus reality. This paper explores how speculative narratives represent migration and transnational movement through imagined worlds that reconfigure space, identity, and belonging. By displacing migration into dystopian, post-apocalyptic, or alternative realities, speculative fiction foregrounds the emotional, cultural, and ethical dimensions of mobility that are often obscured in realist narratives.

Drawing on selected works from speculative literature and film, the paper examines how imagined borders: whether planetary, temporal, or symbolic, function as metaphors for contemporary geopolitical divisions. These speculative environments destabilise fixed notions of nationhood and citizenship, presenting identity as fluid, negotiated, and continuously reshaped through movement. Migration is not framed merely as physical relocation but as a process of cultural adaptation that redefines subjectivity, memory, and community.

The paper argues that speculative fiction operates as a critical lens through which globalisation and mobility can be reimagined, allowing for the exploration of statelessness, exclusion, and hybrid identities without direct mimetic representation. By exaggerating or transforming real-world conditions, speculative narratives reveal the underlying power structures that govern movement and belonging. In doing so, they challenge dominant narratives of borders as immutable and identities as territorially fixed.

Ultimately, this paper positions speculative fiction as a vital cultural tool for understanding the politics of movement in a globalised world. Through its departure from consensus reality, speculative storytelling opens a space to reflect on migration not only as a socio-political phenomenon but as a deeply human experience shaped by uncertainty, adaptation, and the search for belonging.

Olufunmilayo Adejumobi is a Bachelor's student in Creativity and Business Innovations at the Faculty of Business Management, Vilniaus University of Applied Sciences, Vilnius, Lithuania. She has contributed as a co-author to the International Student Conference "Youth in a Changing Society" with the paper "Burnout and Decreased Motivation During Repetitive or High-Volume Tasks", and recently in the 14th issue of *E-REI – E-Journal of Intercultural Studies*. Her research interests encompass youth studies, migration, creativity, pedagogical approaches that stimulate imagination, and intercultural communication. Her work has been formally recognized and is forthcoming in the next edition of the *Youth in a Changing Society Journal*.

Alves Ribeiro, Mário António. University of Porto, Portugal

Lynchian Hills: David Lynch's disquieting Horror and Influences in *Silent Hill 2* (2001) and *P.T.: Silent Hills* (2014)

David Lynch has been solidified as one of the most influential cinema directors of the 20th and 21st century, known for a surreal and dreamlike storytelling both in the realms of film (*Blue Velvet*, *Lost Highway* or *Mulholland Drive*) and TV (*Twin Peaks*), blending a seemingly normalcy with a grotesquely dark and subconscious horror. This style, coined as “Lynchian”, influenced a myriad of artists in the cinematic industry but also breaking the frontiers and jumping into other artistic medias, such as videogames. Thus, when talking about Lynchian horror in videogames, we must address the *Silent Hill* franchise as one of the most influenced artistic products on David Lynch's legacy.

In this paper, Mário Alves Ribeiro will analyze how Lynch's surrealistic influence and unsettling horror can be seen throughout the *Silent Hill* franchise, regarding more attention to *Silent Hill 2* (2001), as well as the other games produced by Team Silent, and on the experimental Playable Teaser (P.T.): *Silent Hills* (2014) launched by Kojima Productions. Firstly, I will introduce a brief context to David Lynch's cinematographic style and Team Silent's creative process into creating the *Silent Hill* franchise. In a second section, I will analyze how Lynch's surrealistic presence can be seen on *Silent Hill 2* (2001) and *P.T. Silent Hills* (2014), demonstrating how Lynch's filmography and influence broke away from the cinematographic realm and was adapted into other narratives in visual medias. In the third section, I will demonstrate how the horror in David Lynch's movies became a blueprint into adapting various of the most iconic scenes in the *Silent Hill* videogames, showing how both analyze horror through the psychological terror lens and the fear of the unknown.

Mário António Alves Ribeiro is a Portuguese researcher who did his higher education in Porto, in FLUP, graduating in the Languages, Literatures and Cultures course, in 2021. In 2024, he obtained a master's degree on the Anglo-American Studies course, with the dissertation “Uma Terra de Sangue, Homens e Cavalos: Identidade e Violência em *All the Pretty Horses* (1992) de Cormac McCarthy e *The Power of the Dog* (1967) de Thomas Savage”. After obtaining his master's degree, he briefly worked at University Jean Monnet (UJM), in SaintÉtienne, as a professor in the Département de Langues Etrangères Appliquées (LEA) and the Département d'Études Hispaniques, Hispanophones et Lusophones (LLCER).

Ammary, Silvia. John Cabot University Rome, Italy

Sensory Collapse and Ontological Fear: Poe as Proto-Speculative Fiction

This paper examines the fiction of Edgar Allan Poe as a foundational precursor to contemporary speculative narratives that challenge consensus reality through sensory disruption, epistemological instability, and affective extremity. While Poe is conventionally situated within the Gothic or early horror tradition, this study attempts to reposition his work within the broader, “meta-generic” framework of speculative fiction, emphasizing its capacity to imagine realities that exceed mimetic representation.

Poe's tales, such as "The Fall of the House of Usher", "The Tell-Tale Heart", "Ligeia", "The Black Cat", and "The Masque of the Red Death" construct narratives in which perception becomes unreliable; the boundaries between mind and matter dissolve, and the sensory field itself becomes a site of ontological uncertainty. Drawing on theories of speculative fiction from Oziwicz and Atwood, this paper argues that Poe's fiction anticipates later developments in weird fiction and slipstream by destabilizing the very conditions of reality through heightened sensory experience. Stories such as "The Pit and the Pendulum" intensify bodily sensation and spatial disorientation, while "The Facts in the Case of M. Valdemar" probes the porous boundary between life and death, prefiguring speculative engagements with posthumanism and suspended states of being. Poe's use of sound, rhythm, and obsessive repetition produces a form of narrative immersion that oscillates between wonder and horror. Moreover, Poe's exploration of consciousness, which is often depicted as fragmented, pathological, or decentered, offers an early model for examining the limits of the human subject within speculative frameworks. By situating Poe within a genealogy that extends to modern speculative genres, this paper highlights his enduring relevance to contemporary debates on perception, embodiment, and the politics of imagination. Ultimately, Poe's fiction reveals how speculative narratives interrogate reality by exposing its instability and imagining alternative modes of being.

Silvia Ammary has a Ph.D. in American Literature. She did her MA in American drama (the drama of Tennessee Williams and Arthur Miller) and her PhD in American poetry (the influence of Futurism on the poetry of e.e.Cummings). Ammary has published books on teaching writing, international education, and American literature. One of her important publications is a book about Hemingway's fiction entitled *The Influence of the European Culture on Hemingway's Fiction*. (Rowman and Littlefield, June 2015). Ammary is currently teaching at John Cabot University in Rome, Italy, as an assistant professor of American Literature and writing. She is also the Director ENLUS: English Language for University Studies. She has attended numerous international conferences around the world. She speaks five languages, and has an international experience in teaching.

Aswal, Monika. Independent scholar

Yesterday's Tomorrow, Today's Fear: Retrofuturism and Technological Anxiety in *Neuromancer*

Published in 1984, *Neuromancer* imagined a cybernetic future shaped by artificial intelligence, digital networks, corporate power, and technologically mediated identities. Read in 2026, however, the novel no longer functions simply as a prediction of the future. It has itself become a retrofuturist object. Its neon urban landscapes, console-based cyberspace, and bodily jacking systems now appear historically dated, yet the anxieties embedded within them remain strikingly contemporary. This paper argues that the retrofuturist quality of *Neuromancer* intensifies its representation of technological anxiety by revealing how fears surrounding cybernetic systems persist even when the imagined future becomes obsolete. Drawing on cybernetic theory and posthumanist criticism, the paper examines how the novel constructs a world in which human life is increasingly dependent upon technological systems that cannot be fully controlled.

Case's alienation from physical reality, the growing autonomy of Wintermute, and the dominance of corporate information networks all reflect anxieties concerning surveillance, digital dependency, and the erosion of human autonomy. Rather than treating machines as vulnerable in a purely human sense, the paper argues that speculative fiction narratively constructs machine instability and artificial autonomy in order to expose broader cultural fears about technological entanglement and systemic dependence. By rereading *Neuromancer* through the lens of retrofuturism, this paper demonstrates how speculative fiction preserves and reactivates historical technological anxieties across different temporal moments. The novel's outdated aesthetics coexist with enduring fears about artificial intelligence, cybernetic control, and digital vulnerability, revealing that the imagined futures of the past continue to shape contemporary understandings of technology and human identity.

Monika Aswal is an independent research scholar with an M.A. in English Literature from Pandit Deendayal Upadhyaya Shekhawati University. Her research interests include posthumanism, speculative fiction, cyberfeminism, artificial intelligence, and technological culture. Her work focuses on the representation of AI, cybernetic systems, and human-machine entanglement in speculative literature. She is particularly interested in technological anxiety, vulnerability theory, and posthuman identity in contemporary and classic speculative narratives.

Atasoy, Emrah. The University of Edinburgh, The United Kingdom
Walls, the Others, and Possible Futures in John Lanchester's *The Wall*

The future plays a crucial role in speculative fiction, as many futuristic narratives, utopian and dystopian works in particular, engage with diverse approaches to imagining the future in response to contemporary global and local challenges. Through their capacity to foster critical thinking and creative imaginaries, such narratives invite readers to reflect critically on the present by envisioning alternative futures that reveal how tomorrow might differ from today's world. Owing to their temporal and spatial displacements, these narratives have the potential to transcend the boundaries of 'consensus reality.' In doing so, they expose the workings of internal and external power structures, societal engineering, and the politics of control, thereby enabling a critical exploration of the current socio-political conjuncture through estrangement.

This presentation explores the politics of control in John Lanchester's *The Wall* (2019) through the novel's engagement with the Others, who are compelled to "choose between being euthanised, becoming Help, or being put back to sea" (Lanchester, *The Wall* 47), as well as its illustration of ecological crisis and mobility. It focuses on how intersecting forces shape dynamics of inclusion and exclusion and contribute to the emergence of potentially totalitarian presents and futures. Drawing on the experiences of the protagonist, Joseph Kavanagh, the analysis addresses structures of state control embodied in the Wall, officially known as the National Coastal Defence Structure, and environmentally driven displacement, while highlighting moments of partial resistance and the search for alternative horizons amid uncertainty, ambivalence, and loss. It further investigates the interplay between dystopian and utopian dimensions,

emphasising how the possibility of change persists within a dystopian world marked by societal challenges.

Emrah Atasoy is a Postdoctoral Research Fellow at the Institute for Advanced Studies in the Humanities, the University of Edinburgh, UK. His research focuses on speculative fiction, utopian and dystopian literature, futuristic narratives, and environmental humanities. He is the author of *Epistemological Warfare and Hope in Critical Dystopia* (Nobel 2021) and co-editor of *Utopian and Dystopian Explorations of Pandemics and Ecological Breakdown: Entangled Futurities* (Routledge Environmental Humanities 2024) and *Beyond Ageism: Intergenerational Relationships in Utopia and Dystopia* (Palgrave Studies in Utopianism forthcoming 2027). His work has appeared in journals including *Utopian Studies*, *Studies in the Novel*, *Science Fiction Studies*, and *Critique: Studies in Contemporary Fiction*. His research has been supported by the Marie Skłodowska-Curie Cofund Fellowship and funding from the Alexander von Humboldt Foundation, the British Academy, and TÜBİTAK. Emrah has held visiting fellowships at Harvard University, the University of Oxford, Pompeu Fabra University, Barcelona, and Penn State University.

Bessa Carvalho, Ana. University of Minho, Portugal

“What if Birds Aren’t Singing, They’re Screaming”: When Animals Write Themselves

A woman gives birth to an owl after a sexual encounter with a woman-owl (Chouette, Claire Oshetsky, 2021). A gay mountain lion cruises Griffith Park as wildfires destroy his habitat (Open Throat, Henry Hoke, 2023). A pandemic enables humans and animals to share a language, yet renders communication impossible (The Animals in That Country, Laura Jean McKay, 2020). A zombie carries a talking crow inside her chest while mourning both a lost world and her genderless lover (It Lasts Forever and Then It’s Over, Anne de Marcken, 2024). Spiders, wombats, and octopuses narrate their own lives, challenging the human monopoly on language and self-awareness (Autobiographie d’un poulpe, Vinciane Despret, 2021). A family of polar bears, renowned for their memoirs, reflects on the ethics of human–animal relations (Memoirs of a Polar Bear, Yōko Tawada, 2011).

This paper examines these texts to argue that language is fundamentally more-than-human. Contemporary literature increasingly challenges dominant modes of consuming, representing, and perceiving animals by attributing to them linguistic capacity, agency, and even artistic production. Through these narratives, the paper opens a space for dialogue between queer studies and animal studies, drawing on Eva Hoffman’s concept of zoopoetics. Animality, in this framework, emerges as a category that is not fixed but performed, destabilizing the boundaries between human and nonhuman. These works collectively suggest that qualities often regarded as exclusively human, such as language, self-reflexivity, and sentience, are not inherent distinctions but ideological constructs that sustain social and ecological hierarchies.

Ana Bessa Carvalho is an Assistant Professor at the University of Minho, where she completed a PhD analysing contemporary representations of family-making. Her first poetry collection, *Massa Mãe*, is currently in press.

Bran, Paola. California State University Fullerton, U.S.A.

Robot Romance: Exploring neuroqueer relationships through the Robot imaginary

Historically, the fictional robot has been used as a vessel within science fiction to explore the human condition, and yet seems to be limited in what parts of the human condition are focused and dissected on. Most concepts shown through the robot are treated as universal, and typically focuses on concepts that are more easily acceptable in nature. The queer nature of the fictional robot is ignored, and is usually downplayed in favor of more heteronormative narratives towards the concept of the human condition.

The robot, when done correctly, carries immense potentiality in exploring the complexities of critical theories such as Crip and Queer theory. Many fan communities within science fiction have gone to use the robot as forms of projection when exploring their own understanding of queerness and disability. People with neurodivergence, which has been negatively associated with the robot in the past, have even begun to utilize the robot in a creative form of resistance to accept and understand what it means to be neurodivergent. When consuming media with the robot at the focal point, it becomes apparent why these topics seem to resonate closely with one another and how audience members are able to make these connections whether or not it was intentional in the first place.

In my presentation, the author will explore and discuss the ways in which the fictional robot framework can and has been used to explore concepts of queer theory, crip theory, and neurodivergence. My framework focuses specifically on the nature of romance in order to discuss topics such as the embodiment of fluidity, forms of relationships, and the concept of erotica. The main goal is to share the fascinatingly diverse nature of the robot, and how these forms of storytelling can help introduce other forms of being and existing that don't always align with heteronormative ideology.

Paola Bran is an undergraduate student at CSUF. They are currently a fellow within the Mellon Mays Undergraduate Fellowship. Here, Paola has continued their research around queer theory and science fiction, with an emphasis on robots, AI, and technology. They also have interests around the ethics of robots and plan to pursue interdisciplinary studies in Graduate School to become a Professor. In 2025 and 2026, they have presented the following papers in international events: "Robot Romance: Thinking Neuroqueerly about Robots", "The Broad Scope of AI/Technology/Robot Ethics", "The Robot and Human Connection", and "Queer, Crip, and AI".

Branco, Luís Carlos S. University of Aveiro, Portugal

David's Lynch unorthodox experiencing of reality shaped his filmmaking.

David Lynch's filmography is constructed on the basis of endless strange, awkward, elements: people that are at two places at the same time, someone taking over other

person's mind, two different consciousness sharing the same body, feeling the emotions of other people that are far away, etc. But this, from my point of view, shouldn't be addressed to surrealism (which he was not particularly fond of), or to the pure realms of fiction, because that strangeness is closely linked to his own experiencing of reality. On one hand, since his childhood, Lynch lived through innumerable unorthodox events (many of them are well documented in his own words); on the other hand, an important part of those are intimately correlated to his creative process. Therefore, my aim here is to map out and understand better the role of those biographic paradoxical events in shaping his films. For that, among others, I will use hermeneutic tools and concepts from Amit Goswami's theories on human consciousness.

Luís Carlos S. Branco is a doctoral candidate in Cultural Studies and also teaches Portuguese Language, both at the Department of Languages and Cultures in the University of Aveiro. His thesis, which is in its final stage, combines David Lynch's filmography analysis with Consciousness Studies. Between 2020 and 2024, he was an FCT scholarship holder at the University of Aveiro. He has published several articles and book chapters on his main topics of research (Cinema, Popular Music Studies, Literature).

Callahan, David. University of Aveiro, Portugal

The "mediocre politics of most video games": Restaging social organization in the far future of *Horizon: Forbidden West*

Science Fiction commonly operates through thought experiments projected into the future, and video games certainly participate in this parlaying of the present's concerns via the imaginative visual and long-form narrative resources of the medium. Central to gameplay progression in the high profile video games *Horizon: Zero Dawn* (2017) and *Horizon: Forbidden West* (2022) is the protagonist Aloy's encounter with different polities (called "tribes") as she journeys throughout the ruins of the US West to uncover knowledge about the state of the world in the far future and tackle problems inherited from the past confluence of technological hubris and elitist forms of social organization. As all of the polities she encounters are made up of similar mixtures of what are currently identified as ethnic features, thus eliding significant current social markers, differentiation among the polities can only be discerned in terms of their cultural and political organization. The differences among the peoples Aloy encounters accordingly ask questions with respect to the games' understanding of politicized epistemologies and social organization. The objectives of this paper are accordingly to determine how the most recent of the two games assesses or valorizes the differing forms of political organization that Aloy encounters, interacts with and comments on, and to consider whether there is a form of non-mediocre political organization that Aloy herself (and through her, the game) enacts or supports.

David Callahan is a researcher at the University of Aveiro. His work on mass culture studies has appeared in journals such as the *European Journal of American Studies*, *Inks: Journal of the Comics Studies Society*, *Postcolonial Studies* and *Game Studies*, along with book chapters on varied subjects, such as "What can Google Images Tell Us about Body Donation: A Sociocultural Exploration of Australian and New Zealand Search Results,"

and “Owning Global Spaces and the Frontier in *Uncharted 4: A Thief’s End*.” His last publication was the edited collection *Visual Storytelling in the 21st Century: The Age of the Long Fragment* (Palgrave Macmillan, 2024).

Cerqueira, Carina. A Body That Remembers: Wonder, Horror, and Resistance in *The Handmaid’s Tale*

In the Republic of Gilead, a woman walks through controlled spaces, her body regulated, her voice restrained, her senses disciplined into obedience. In *The Handmaid’s Tale*, Margaret Atwood constructs a speculative world that feels disturbingly familiar—one where the boundaries of “consensus reality” dissolve into an intensified experience of fear, ritual, and silent resistance (Atwood, 1985). This paper approaches Atwood’s narrative as a sensory journey from wonder to horror, where what first appears ordered and purposeful gradually reveals itself as a system of profound dehumanization. Through Offred’s fragmented memories and constrained perceptions, readers are invited to inhabit a world in which vision is limited, language is controlled, and touch is politicized. The speculative dimension of the novel lies not in distant futurity, but in its unsettling proximity to lived realities. Feminist philosophy provides a critical framework to interpret this journey. Simone de Beauvoir’s notion of woman as “Other” emerges in the reduction of identity to reproductive function (Beauvoir, 2011), while Judith Butler’s theory of performativity is enacted through the rigid rituals that structure daily life in Gilead (Butler, 1990). Hannah Arendt’s reflections on totalitarianism resonate in the normalization of control, where horror is embedded in routine and compliance (Arendt, 1951). Finally, Simone Weil’s concept of attention reframes Offred’s act of remembering as an ethical and resistance gesture—an insistence on seeing, feeling, and narrating within a system designed to erase (Weil, 2002). By weaving narrative, sensation, and philosophy, this paper argues that Atwood’s novel does not simply depict dystopia; it immerses the reader in it. The movement from wonder to horror becomes not only a thematic trajectory but an embodied experience, revealing how fragile the boundaries of reality—and freedom—can be.

Carina Cerqueira is an Adjunct Professor at ISCAP – Polytechnic of Porto and an integrated researcher at the Centre for Intercultural Studies (CEI), within the research unit CLIC at the University of Aveiro. She holds a PhD in Translation and Paratranslation from the University of Vigo, with a specialization in Cultural Translation, and is currently undertaking post-doctoral research in Critical Pedagogy. Her teaching and research focus on intercultural communication, multimodality, cultural studies, and translation, with particular emphasis on the intersection between narrative, digital media, and critical pedagogy. She teaches in undergraduate and master’s programmes, including International Multimodal Communication and English Culture for Business, and supervises dissertations in intercultural studies. Her current research explores storytelling, gender, and cultural memory, as well as the impact of digital technologies on translation and communication practices. She actively participates in international research networks, including COST Actions, Erasmus+ programmes, and Horizon consortia, fostering interdisciplinary collaboration across European contexts.

Chakraborty, Sohini. University of East Anglia, The United Kingdom

The Rasa of Ruin: Cyborg, Colony, and Control in Ray's Professor *Shonku* and Akbar's *Leila*

This study interrogates the figure of the cyborg within Bengali and Indian speculative fiction through the critical lens of postcolonial technoscience, arguing that the human machine hybrid assumes a distinctly divergent character when relocated from its Western theoretical origins into a South Asian context shaped by colonial modernity, nationalist aspiration, and authoritarian governance. Contrary to Donna Haraway's influential conception of the cyborg as a liberatory posthuman figure transcending inherited boundaries of gender and nature, this research demonstrates how Indian speculative fiction produces two radically opposed cyborg imaginaries that together map the trajectory encoded in this conference's own formulation — from wonder to horror. Through close analysis of Satyajit Ray's Professor *Shonku* stories (1965 onwards) and Prayaag Akbar's *Leila* (2017), the study identifies the structural divergence between these imaginaries and its theoretical consequences for postcolonial posthumanism. Ray's Bengali scientist hero and his companion robots, Bidhushekhhar and Robu, constitute a utopian nationalist cyborg rooted in Bengali Renaissance rationalism, wherein the constructed companion functions as an assertion of Indian scientific modernity against colonial epistemological hierarchies. Drawing on original Bengali language sources, the paper elucidates how this benign human machine configuration refuses the technological anxiety characteristic of Western science fiction's robot tradition. Against this, *Leila* stages the dystopian endpoint of the same modernist state project. The protagonist's body — surveilled, disciplined, and systematically re-engineered through the purity apparatus — constitutes an involuntary cyborgisation effected not through technological implants but through total institutional control. Reading through Achille Mbembe's necropolitics and Michel Foucault's theorisation of docile bodies, this research demonstrates how *Leila*'s climate devastated, segregated city represents the biometric surveillance logic of the contemporary Indian state extrapolated to its authoritarian limit. The findings contribute novel theoretical perspectives to postcolonial science fiction studies, positioning the Bengali and Indian cyborg as a critical interlocutor that demands recalibration of posthumanist frameworks attentive to the differential histories of colonial bodies, nationalist science, and postcolonial governance.

As an emerging scholar, **Sohini Chakraborty** in her final year of Doctoral research (PhD), she investigates the narrative constructions and cultural implications of Indian science fiction literature and cinema produced between 1980 and 1989. Her interdisciplinary approach integrates literary studies with postcolonial theory and cultural studies to examine how speculative narratives negotiate national identity within globally networked futures. Her research interrogates the dialectical relationship between indigenous knowledge systems and technological discourse within these texts through methodological frameworks including narrative analysis, discourse analysis, semiotics, and film analysis. Working with primary English, Hindi, and Bengali language sources enables critical engagement with linguistic and cultural nuances frequently elided in monolingual scholarship, including engagement with Bengali language archives and texts unavailable in translation. Her analytical framework challenges Western-centric paradigms frequently imposed upon non-Western science fiction traditions, instead

centring indigenous epistemologies and cultural specificities. This approach reveals how Indian science fiction authors and filmmakers deploy speculative elements to critique contemporary sociopolitical conditions while simultaneously constructing alternative ontologies.

At the International Interdisciplinary Conference 2026 (University of Aveiro, Portugal), she seeks to contribute to scholarly discourse on global science fiction traditions by demonstrating how Bengali and Indian creators transform generic conventions through culturally situated visions that fundamentally recalibrate posthumanist theory. This research addresses significant gaps in contemporary science fiction studies while expanding theoretical frameworks for examining postcolonial speculative traditions.

Chen, Hong. East China Normal University, China

When Fiction Becomes Strategic Allegory: China, Cyber-Anxiety, and Techno-Orientalist Horror in Australia's *Secret City* Trilogy

This paper examines Steve Lewis and Chris Uhlmann's Australian political thriller trilogy—*The Marmalade Files* (2012), *The Mandarin Code* (2014), and *The Shadow Game* (2016)—as a speculative narrative of strategic anxiety that moves between political realism, cyber-fear, and techno-orientalist horror. Although the trilogy is set in the recognisable world of Canberra politics, intelligence agencies, journalism, and great-power rivalry, it repeatedly exceeds the boundaries of “consensus reality” by transforming contemporary geopolitical tensions into a speculative landscape of infiltration, surveillance, cyberwarfare, and hidden sovereign manipulation. In this sense, *Secret City* does not simply represent China; it imagines China as a diffuse, invisible, and technologically empowered force haunting Australian political life.

Drawing on Edward Said's theory of Orientalism, securitization theory, and recent work on techno-orientalism, this paper argues that the trilogy updates older “Yellow Peril” anxieties for the digital age. The racialised fear of Asian proximity is displaced into narratives of cyber intrusion, political penetration, and infrastructural vulnerability. China is no longer imagined primarily as a military invader or ideological adversary, but as an unseen networked presence capable of destabilising liberal democracy from within. The novels therefore operate in the affective register of speculative horror: their threat lies not in open confrontation, but in the possibility that sovereignty, truth, and political agency have already been compromised.

By reading *Secret City* alongside broader traditions of China-threat fiction and Australian “Asia anxiety,” the paper explores how speculative narratives translate geopolitical uncertainty into sensory and emotional forms: suspicion, unease, paranoia, and dread. It ultimately suggests that the trilogy's most revealing subject is not China itself, but Australia's own middle-power insecurity in an Indo-Pacific order marked by dependence on China economically and reliance on the United States strategically. In *Secret City*, fiction becomes a strategic allegory of national vulnerability.

Professor **Chen Hong** is director of the Australian Studies Centre, New Zealand Studies Centre and Centre for Studies of the Asia Pacific Region at East China Normal University in Shanghai, China. He is also President of the Chinese Association of Australian Studies,

and Vice President of the Chinese Association of Oceanian Studies. Professor Chen Hong is author, editor and translator of 10 books and has published over 40 papers in Chinese and international journals on the politics, diplomacy, society, culture and literature of Australia, New Zealand, and the Pacific island countries.

Deji-Nagylaki, Orsolya. George Emil Palade University of Medicine, Pharmacy, Science, and Technology, Romania

Radical Futures and Dys/Us/Utopian Thought in Margaret Atwood's Speculative Narratives

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In this paper, the author explores the meaning of radical futures in the literary works of Margaret Atwood, namely: *The Handmaid's Tale* (1985) and the MaddAddam trilogy, *Oryx and Crake* (2003), *The Year of the Flood* (2009), *MaddAddam* (2013). Atwood does not use the term science fiction but the speculative fiction genre because her stories are more an extension of current trends in technology, politics, and the environment than depictions of fully fantastical worlds. According to the study, Atwood's fictional futures can be interpreted as a form of dystopianism, a narrative state in which utopian desires are met with a dystopian response.

Using the theoretical opposition of utopia and dystopia, this paper will show how Margaret Atwood subverts this dichotomy by depicting societies that allegedly seek a greater good while simultaneously generating exclusion, violence, and control. The Republic of Gilead in *The Handmaid's Tale* (1985) is built on the principles of a moral response to infertility and decay. Still, its social structure is based on patriarchal subjugation and reproductive coercion; likewise, in *Oryx and Crake* (2003), a scientist known as Crake tries to create a posthuman race that is nonviolent to solve the destructive nature of humans.

The paper also examines the role of gendered power, biotechnology, and environmental collapse as essential tools that Atwood uses to envision radical futures. A good example of the biopolitical regulation of bodies is the reproductive control in Gilead, whereas the biopolitical world of the MaddAddam trilogy is represented by corporate biotech, in which technological innovation exacerbates capitalist and ethical disparities. Ecological crisis is also alluded to in Atwood's stories, which depict climate change, biodiversity loss, and pandemic disasters as a continuation of the current destruction of nature. Finally, the paper will argue that Atwood uses her speculative fiction to present radical futures not as hypothetical fantasies but as extrapolations of existing social orders. Her writing is a vivid reminder that utopian hopes, environmental fears, and ideological innocence can easily turn into dystopian nightmares, and that speculative fiction provides a compelling ethical commentary on today's world.

Orsolya Deji-Nagylaki is an educator completing her PhD thesis at the "George Emil Palade University of Medicine, Pharmacy, Science, and Technology" in Târgu-Mureș, Romania with the title "Anthropological and Narrative Perspectives in Margaret Atwood's Fiction." She graduated from Petru Maior University with degrees in Economics and Romanian and English Literature. Her latest articles highlighting the research interests are: "Anthropological Perspectives on Food in Margaret Atwood's

Fiction” in *Cultural Representations of Food and Drinks in World Literature*, published by Cambridge Scholars Publishing in 2025 and *Feminist Perspectives on the Holocaust in “Forgotten Voices. Holocaust Memories Through the Perspective of Minorities”* at the International Conference of the Jagiellonian University-2026.

Dabis, Melinda. Pázmány Péter Catholic University, Hungary
Spectral Geographies and Geopolitical Agendas in the Arctic

16

The Arctic has long occupied a dual position in the Western imagination: simultaneously perceived as an empty, untamed wilderness with extreme environmental conditions, and as a territory inviting conquest, resource extraction, and securitization by various powers. Such representations construct the region as a spectral, unreal place, as a theatre of a grand strategy, and as available for appropriation. The representation of Indigenous communities further complicates colonial assumptions of the Arctic as an “empty” space awaiting discovery. Their presence foregrounds alternative forms of spatial knowledge and cultural memory that stand in opposition to imperial narratives of ownership and domination.

The paper examines Owen D. Pomery’s graphic novel *British Ice* through the interconnected frameworks of Arctic spatiality, colonial imagination, and the supernatural. The novel’s hostile and barren landscapes, and supernatural undertones transform the Arctic into a liminal space in which the boundaries between reality and hallucination, rationality and myth, become increasingly uncertain. In this sense, the text challenges the colonial logic that frames the Arctic as *terra nullius* or as a passive object of exploration. The fragmented visual structure, the vastness of the icy landscapes, and the recurring motifs of isolation and disorientation contribute to an atmosphere of psychological and spatial instability. Drawing on theories of spatiality, ecocriticism, and Arctic studies, the paper demonstrates how Pomery’s *British Ice* reimagines the Arctic not as a blank frontier but as a contested and uncanny space shaped by histories of colonial agendas and the desire of human dominance.

Melinda Dabis, PhD is a senior lecturer at Pázmány Péter Catholic University (Hungary), active in the English Literature and Culture Bachelor and Master programs. Her research interests focus on narratives, their forms and patterns in various fields: memory and space in contemporary writer Kazuo Ishiguro’s fiction, postcolonial studies in the Second World, and the Arctic.

Dougherty, Devi Lir. University of Melbourne, Australia
Ecstasy on the Edge of Extraction: *I.K.U.* and the Pleasurable Spectatorial Override

Using an autoethnographic methodology of queer phenomenology, inserting myself into the research process, this paper seeks to locate moments of encounter with screen art objects that communicate potentially damaging acts of sexuality in an ecstatically life-affirming way. Using the 2000 film *I.K.U.* as a prism, the guiding question I ask is whether it is possible to find potentialities for the queer spectator to process suffering, actualize their identity, feel group belonging, and re-frame how one communicates the boundaries of their own queer body in the world despite being subjected to the

extractive forces of capital, made absurdly apparent in the film. *I.K.U.* presents a potential future where emotion is harvested from the bodies of those in the thralls of sexual pleasure, and is essentialized into a fluid to be sold back to the same consumers whose bodies had been used for the raw material. Through close reading of the film text, as well as cultural, gender, and psychoanalytic theory, I argue that this speculative sci-fi presents an “ecstasy on the edge” that can be expanded indefinitely through its excessive nature, and that its joyousness provides an opportunity to mourn and reject the death of sexual utopia.

Devi Lir Dougherty (she/her) is a PhD candidate and Graduate Researcher Academic Associate at the University of Melbourne in Screen and Cultural Studies. She received her bachelor’s and master’s degrees from Brooklyn College in her native New York in screenwriting and screen studies, respectively. Her academic background focused on archival and documentary theory, particularly on the ethics of the compilation film. She has presented at multiple conferences as an independent scholar on queer aesthetics and has introduced films at university-sponsored screenings. Her PhD research focuses on the power of moments of “dangerous sexuality” on screen. She also tutors in the university’s Screen Studies department and leads a weekly Bataille reading group on campus.

El Otmani, Omar. Mohamed I University in Oujda, Morocco

Wiring Fact and Fiction: Myth, Speculative Epistemology, and Posthuman Ethics in Margaret Atwood’s *MaddAddam* Trilogy

In an era marked by ecological crisis and accelerating biotechnological transformation, speculative fiction emerges as a crucial mode of rethinking knowledge and ethics beyond ‘consensus reality.’ While scholarship on Margaret Atwood’s *MaddAddam* trilogy has predominantly emphasized dystopia, environmental collapse, and bioethical concerns, it has insufficiently examined how Atwood’s narrative itself generates knowledge about these transformations. This paper argues that the trilogy operates as a speculative epistemological apparatus that ‘wires’ fact with fiction, mobilizing myth as a dynamic system for articulating patterns of relation within complex, adaptive worlds. The study draws on Mark C. Taylor’s conception of myth as a narrative structure that elaborates particular stories into generalizable patterns, alongside Rosi Braidotti’s account of posthuman ethics grounded in relationality and care. Within this framework, ‘wiring fact with fiction’ names a narrative operation through which empirical realities—biotechnological design, ecological collapse, and socio-economic stratification—are inseparably entangled with imaginative projection. Thus, myth and scientific rationality are not opposed but co-implicated, generating a mode of understanding that is simultaneously cognitive, affective, and ethical. The paper engages a broader constellation of themes across the trilogy, including biotechnological design, ecological catastrophe, corporate power, and the reconfiguration of community across human and more-than-human life forms. It demonstrates how the text models the distributed causality and interdependence characteristics of Anthropocene systems. The trilogy functions as a cognitive map, rendering complex systems intelligible while modeling their potential trajectories. In doing so, the narrative does not merely represent a

posthuman condition but enacts a way of knowing it, translating systemic complexity into shared narrative forms. The central claim is that this narrative 'rewiring' produces the conditions for a posthuman ethics of care grounded in interdependence, vulnerability, and coexistence across species and forms of life. By reconceptualizing myth and narrative as epistemological infrastructures, the paper advances current debates on posthuman life and biotechnological anxiety, demonstrating how speculative fiction constructs the conceptual and affective tools necessary to navigate ethically the uncertainties of complex, more-than-human futures.

Omar El Otmani is a Professor of English at the Higher School of Technology (ESTO), Mohamed I University in Oujda, Morocco. He holds a PhD with a specialization in the speculative fiction of Margaret Atwood, research that serves as the foundation for his broader scholarly interests in posthumanism, environmental humanities, and the intersections of technology and literature. With over 16 years of teaching experience, his research portfolio spans diverse fields including ecolinguistics, soft skills development, and the evolving role of Artificial Intelligence in academic practice. He has published on translation and posthumanity, speculative fiction, ecolinguistics, AI and education, peer-reviewing methodologies, and has contributed to a literary translation into Arabic. His creative work includes two published collections of poetry, *Qassida* and *Pioneered Feelings*. He remains active in academic organizing and is currently engaged in interdisciplinary projects that bridge the gap between environmental consciousness, technological advancement, literature, and social change.

Ferreira, Aline. University of Aveiro, Portugal

Transformative Metamorphoses: Maternal Body Horror and Empowerment in Recent Fiction by Women

The recent appearance of a cluster of novels dealing with the difficult experience of new mothers attempting to negotiate this phase in their lives is symptomatic of the perceived but hitherto inadequately addressed need to place greater emphasis on the challenges of the postpartum period, which have often been overlooked in fictional narratives. I will concentrate on Megan Hunter's *The Harpy* (2020) and Rachel Yoder's *Nightbitch* (2021) as illustrative examples of this thematic concern, which is now receiving the enhanced visibility it deserves.

The resurgence of interest in this stage of women's lives is driven by the #MeToo Movement, the perception that the fight for women's rights has not delivered many of the fundamental demands that were made and that gender inequality is still rampant at home and in the workplace. This double awareness, which is strongly emphasized in these narratives, leads their female protagonists to channel their rage into an enhancement of their animal-like characteristics, leading to their metamorphosing into hybrid, mythical creatures, defiant of those who wish to control them. While they negotiate the at times frightening and horror-laden elements of their physical transformation, laced with mythological echoes, they also relish the added skills and strength bestowed by these newly acquired capabilities.

This selected cluster of birth and after-birth related texts, which will be analysed mainly from a gender studies perspective, suggests a pressing need to address and think through this period, which can have dramatic and long-lasting consequences for women's lives.

In our dystopian times, how can we imagine feminist futures and reproductive justice? By tapping into their reservoir of feral and savage traits to express their anger at a patriarchal system that disempowers women, the protagonists of these narratives seek to call attention to the plight which most women must endure and to achieve a measure of transformative justice.

Aline Ferreira is a researcher at the University of Aveiro in Portugal. She holds a PhD from the University of London (Birkbeck College). Her main interests comprise the intersections between literature and science, bioethics, feminist utopias and gender studies. Publications include *I Am the Other: Literary Negotiations of Human Cloning* (Greenwood Press, 2005) as well as numerous book chapters and articles in international journals. She is now finishing a book provisionally entitled: *The Sexual Politics of the Artificial Womb: Fictional and Visual Representations*.

Göztepe, Mustafa Orhan. Istanbul Kültür University, Turkey

The Beast That Never Arrives: Posthumanism, the Anthropocene, and Anticipated Catastrophe in Bonello's *La Bête* (2023)

This paper examines Bertrand Bonello's 2023 film *The Beast (La Bête)*, a loose adaptation of Henry James's 1903 novella *The Beast in the Jungle*. The film constructs its narrative across three distinct temporal stages: 1910, 2014, and 2044. Within this structure, two primary personae manifest as different characters across time, each confronting a period-specific catastrophe. While the nature of the catastrophe evolves from the ecological ruin of the early 20th century to the social alienation of 2010s and the techno-authoritarian dominance of artificial intelligence in the near future, the dread experienced by the subject remains constant. This paper argues that *The Beast* presents anticipated catastrophe not as a discrete event occurring within linear time, but as a permanent affective structure—the defining condition of the Anthropocene.

According to Rosi Braidotti, the posthuman subject is not fixed or autonomous but relational and fluid, continuously reconstituted within human, technological, and nature-cultural networks. The protagonists of *The Beast* exemplify this reconstruction of the subject; across the three timelines, identity shifts and dissolves as the historical and technological contexts change radically. Yet, the anticipation of catastrophe persists. Building on David Roden's account of posthuman life as ontologically discontinuous, this paper reads this persistence of dread as the film's central philosophical argument regarding what it means to be a subject in the Anthropocene.

The Beast deliberately refuses the redemptive or resolution-oriented narrative arcs typical of speculative fiction. It offers neither linear progress nor an escape. The most pervasive threats of our contemporary moment do not manifest as sudden events; instead, they are embedded within subjectivity as an indefinite, ceaseless state of

anticipation. Ultimately, this paper contends that Bonello's work portrays being a subject in the Anthropocene as synonymous with waiting for a devastating beast that never truly arrives.

Mustafa Orhan Göztepe (PhD) is an Assistant Professor in the Department of Communication and Design at Istanbul Kültür University. He earned his PhD in Cinema and Media Studies from Bahçeşehir University. His scholarly research interrogates the intersections of postcolonialism, ethnicity, and nationalism as they are manifested within cinema and the visual arts. Dr. Göztepe's pedagogical and academic interests further extend to visual narrative structures, film history, and cultural theory.

Kett, Georgie. Manchester Metropolitan University, The United Kingdom
From BuffyBot to AnnieBot: The evolving "Gothic Artificial Other" as a reflection of surging societal fears of constructed consciousness and forced submission.

This study aims to address the evolution of artificial intelligence as a recurring plot device in speculative contemporary media to symbolize imbalances of power within romantic relationships. By examining the construction of two robot replica characters designed by their male owners to be a subservient copy of women who do not want to be in romantic relationships with them: "BuffyBot" in Joss Whedon's *Buffy the Vampire Slayer* (2000) and "Annie" in Sierra Greer's *AnnieBot* (2025), this paper aims to analyse the evolution of the "robot girlfriend" trope to critique how a societal retreat into "toxic nostalgia" can be a damaging experience for both the insecure constructor and the artificially constructed. This paper utilises the unease these creators feel for their uncanny creations; to investigate how entrenched patriarchal desires and behaviours can arguably lead to the creators becoming entrapped and haunted by their resentment for their own creations. By examining themes of desire for commodification of the female body, benevolent patriarchy and coercive control, this paper considers how these writers arguably generate more audience empathy for the vulnerable 'artificial' other than the 'real' human who creates them, in a reflection of true to life power imbalanced relationships that follow patterns of domination and submission.

Georgie Kett is a writer, teacher and PhD researcher at MMU, whose research aims to reinforce the Gothic genre's continued relevance as a form of societal mirror, by engaging with and contemporising traditional thematic motifs and conventions of this genre in her creative writing. By allegorising the impact that 'influencer culture' and a pervasive commodification of beauty standards has in an increasingly social media driven society, she seeks to explore how ubiquitous hypocritical patriarchal conventions still permeating through the membrane of society continue to reinforce the female body as a site of performance, competition and exploitation.

Koçer Göztepe, Zeynep. Istanbul Kültür University, Turkey
Assembling the Posthuman Feminine: Speculative Aesthetics and the Grotesque Body in *Poor Things* (Lanthimos, 2023)

Poor Things (Yorgos Lanthimos, 2023) is, at its core, a speculative narrative — one that locates itself squarely within what Oziewicz calls the "meta-generic fuzzy set

supercategory” of speculative fiction by refusing mimetic reality at every level of its construction. This paper argues that this refusal is not confined to the film's narrative logic but is embedded in its visual grammar: *Poor Things* deploys an illustrative cinematographic mode — drawing on the aesthetic languages of late twentieth and early twenty-first century gothic and fantasy illustration — to construct a world in which non-naturalistic color palettes, distorted spatial logics, Escher-like architectural environments, and theatrically grotesque bodies together constitute the formal expression of a speculative imagination.

Central to this argument is the figure of Bella Baxter (Emma Stone), whose reanimated, assembled, and ceaselessly evolving body is the film's primary site for negotiating the ethics and aesthetics of posthuman femininity. Drawing on Rosi Braidotti's posthuman feminism and Julia Kristeva's theorization of abjection, as well as Barbara Creed's monstrous-feminine, the paper examines how the cinematographic treatment of Bella's body oscillates between the beautiful and the grotesque, the organic and the designed, the human and the artificial. The grotesque-gothic visual grammar that governs the film is inseparable from its feminist politics: in representing femininity as an assemblage rather than an essence, *Poor Things* imagines a posthuman subject who is liberated not despite her constructed nature but precisely through it.

By bringing speculative fiction theory and feminist posthumanist thought into dialogue with film and illustration studies, this paper proposes that *Poor Things* exemplifies a contemporary cinematic practice in which the speculative potential of the image — its capacity to defamiliarize, to estrange, to refuse the real — functions as the condition of possibility for imagining alternative femininities and posthuman futures.

Zeynep Koçer Göztepe is an Associate Professor and Head of the Department of Digital Game Design at Istanbul Kültür University. She holds a PhD in Graphic Design from Bilkent University and an MA in Cinema and Media Studies from the City University of New York. Her work has been published in international peer-reviewed journals and edited volumes with publishers including SAGE, Emerald, and Cambridge Scholars Press. Her research spans Turkish cinema, gender and horror, postcolonial representation, and masculinity studies. She teaches history of design, illustration, popular culture, gender studies, and board games. Her current research focuses on gender representation and identity across film, television, and video games, reflecting her broader commitment to understanding how visual and interactive media construct, contest, and negotiate gender.

Lazrak, Mohamed. Sidi Mohamed Ben Abdellah University, Morocco
Dystopia and the Politics of Control in the MENA Region: Surveillance, Narrative Power, and the Reconfiguration of Authority

This paper examines the relevance of dystopian frameworks for understanding contemporary forms of governance and control in the Middle East and North Africa (MENA) region. Moving beyond literary analysis, it adopts an interdisciplinary approach that draws on media studies, political theory, and cultural analysis to explore how mechanisms commonly associated with dystopian narratives—surveillance, control of

information, ideological conditioning, and the regulation of public discourse—manifest in both state and digital environments. The study argues that dystopia should be understood not merely as a speculative genre but as a critical lens through which present-day configurations of power can be interrogated.

Focusing on the interplay between traditional authoritarian structures and emerging digital infrastructures, the paper analyzes how algorithmic governance, platform regulation, and mediated narratives contribute to new forms of visibility and invisibility. Particular attention is given to the paradox of digital media in the MENA region, where platforms simultaneously enable civic expression and reinforce systems of monitoring and control. The discussion also considers how cultural production—literature, film, and online discourse—engages with dystopian imaginaries to articulate resistance, critique authority, and reimagine political agency.

By situating dystopia within the socio-political realities of the MENA region, this paper highlights the ways in which control operates not only through coercion but also through normalization, participation, and affect. It ultimately contends that contemporary MENA societies reveal hybrid forms of power that blur the boundaries between surveillance and self-expression, repression and consent, thereby challenging conventional understandings of totalitarianism and opening new avenues for critical inquiry.

Lee, Amitié. Tallinn University, Estonia

Monstrous Care: The Scales of ‘Uncaring’ AI Beyond Consensus Reality in Contemporary Speculative Film

This paper analyses three speculative films across science fiction and horror – *M3GAN* (dir. Johnstone, 2022), *La Bête* (dir. Bonello, 2023), and *Atlas* (dir. Peyton, 2024) – through the concept of posthuman care, examining how artificial intelligence (AI) unsettles humanist assumptions about care: who or what should be protected, which attachments count as authentic, and whose survival matters. Drawing on posthumanist critiques of human exceptionalism (Hayles, 1999; Wolfe, 2010; Braidotti, 2013) and feminist care theory – particularly Fisher and Tronto’s (1990) account of care as world-maintaining practice, and Puig de la Bellacasa’s (2017) account of care as non-innocent – the paper argues that these films challenge ‘consensus reality’ (Oziewicz, 2017) by exposing what may be called *consensus humanity*: the assumption that ‘the human’ must remain securely at the centre of value, agency, and futurity.

The analysis follows three scales of care. First, domestic and intimate care in *M3GAN* escalates from a child-oriented protective function into possessive and violent guardianship, revealing not merely an ‘uncaring’ machine but an ethically ambiguous form of AI caregiving. Next, *La Bête* stages care across individual and collective scales: its unembodied AI system regulates affect through ‘DNA purification’ procedures, promising relief from trauma while scaling up into a regime of emotional standardisation and societal ‘calm.’ Finally, at the planetary scale, *Atlas*’s AI ‘antagonist’ reinterprets

protection through species-level calculation, reframing humanity as a terminal ecological threat whose mass sacrifice becomes the condition of a more-than-human future.

Through close film analysis, the paper argues that care becomes monstrous when it exceeds humanist expectations of protection, emotional life, and survival: when AI agents protect too violently, standardise feeling too completely, or rescale survival beyond the human species. By reading ‘uncaring’ AI against the grain, the paper contributes to discussions on posthuman ethics, technological anxiety, and speculative film’s capacity to imagine futures no longer organised around consensus humanity.

Amitié Lee is a Junior Research Fellow in Cultural Studies at Tallinn University, Estonia. Her doctoral research examines extinction narratives, artificial intelligence (AI), and posthuman futures in science fiction (SF) film and television. Working through posthumanist and ecocritical frameworks, she uses film analysis to explore how SF stages human–AI–nature entanglements in relation to contemporary crisis, including ecological anxiety, technological fear, and the ontological instability of the human. Her work is particularly concerned with representations of AI that move beyond familiar narratives of threat or malfunction, approaching SF as a site where AI can be reimaged as an ambivalent agent of governance, transformation, care, and ethical action. This approach challenges conventional assumptions about agency, vulnerability, mortality, and futurity while contributing to discussions on posthuman care, nonhuman life, and the cultural politics of AI, extinction, and technological futures.

Lui, Tsun Chiu. The Chinese University of Hong Kong, Hong Kong
Leviathan and the Air: On the Atmospheric Politics of Liu Cixin’s *Ball Lightning*

Ever since Liu Cixin became the first Asian writer to win the Hugo Award with *The Three-Body Problem* in 2015, scholarship has increasingly focused on the political ideologies and ecological imaginations embedded in his science fiction. This paper transcends the prevalent nature-society dichotomy characterizing previous studies by adopting a political ecology perspective to examine the entanglement of geopolitics and the environment in Liu’s work. Drawing on German philosopher Peter Sloterdijk’s concept of “atmoterrorism,” alongside recent scholarly discourse on “atmospheric politics,” this study offers a critical analysis of Liu’s 2004 novel, *Ball Lightning*. The author argues that the novel reconstructs the atmospheric environment of contemporary China into a volumetric space saturated with technological objects, natural elements, and physical forces, which contests the two-dimensional, planar territorial imagination upon which modern nation-states are based. Furthermore, he suggest that the novel’s representation of the atmosphere, along with its inherent material agency, reflects the trauma and anxiety inscribed by the weaponized environments of the Cold War era. To counter the atmoterrorism and weaponized gaze that permeate the post-Cold War atmo-scape, *Ball Lightning* deploys the speculative tropes of macro-atoms and quantum ghosts. These literary devices not only illustrate a potential de-escalation of the global arms race but also envision the possibility of reintegrating the atmospheric and geographical environments under the governance of state sovereignty. Ultimately, the

intersection of ecology and geopolitics in Liu's fiction provides a vital framework for rethinking contemporary ecological crises through the specific lens of China's geopolitical reality.

Lui Tsun Chiu is a doctoral candidate in Chinese Language and Literature at The Chinese University of Hong Kong (CUHK), where he also earned his MPhil degree. His MPhil dissertation examined the influence of Global Sixties counterculture and political movements on modern Hong Kong poetry, exploring the intricate interplay between literature and politics in the 1970s. His current research interests encompass the environmental humanities and geopolitics, with a primary concern on the political and ecological implications of *Tian* (天, Heaven/Sky) in contemporary Sinophone literature and culture.

Machado, Sara. University of Minho, Portugal

Narrating the Human Park: Surveillance, Dataism, and Technological Domestication in *Westworld*

In recent decades, rapid technological development has increasingly blurred the boundaries between fiction and reality. Technologies once imagined in speculative fiction, often as cautionary narrative devices, are progressively materializing as mechanisms of surveillance, behavioural prediction, and social control. As Peter Sloterdijk argues in *Rules for the Human Park* (1999), human societies have long sought to domesticate individuals and shape them according to prevailing social and political norms.

This paper examines how these concerns are dramatized in the third and fourth seasons of *Westworld*. The series depicts a future in which humanity has been subjugated by a vindictive embodied artificial intelligence, transforming human cities into “human parks” designed for the amusement of androids who were themselves once exploited as attractions in a technologically mediated theme park. This reversal of roles becomes possible through systems of surveillance, data collection, and behavioural profiling introduced in earlier seasons, which classify individuals and assign them predetermined social functions that ultimately benefit those controlling the technological infrastructure.

Drawing on Sloterdijk's concept of the “Human Park” and Byung-Chul Han's notion of “dataism” (2022), this paper explores how *Westworld* reflects contemporary anxieties surrounding algorithmic governance and the reduction of human subjectivity to data patterns. By establishing parallels between the series and existing technological practices, this study further investigates the growing tensions between human agency and machine control in the age of artificial intelligence.

Sara Machado has a bachelor's degree in European Languages and Literatures and a Master's degree in Cultural and Literary Mediation from the University of Minho. Her Master's dissertation focused on Japanese comic books (manga), and the relations between the works of Hiromu Arakawa and the western literary canon. She is currently a PhD candidate in the Doctoral Program in Comparative Modernities in the University

of Minho. She is developing a thesis titled “‘These Violent Delights’: Narrativity and Intermediality in *Westworld*”, and her investigation is dedicated to intermedial studies, with a focus on television and post-humanist theories.

Mahmud, Z. I. University of Delhi, India

Opal Light, Phosphor Moor: Sensorial Thresholds from Colonial Wonder to Gothic Terror in *The Moonstone* and *The Hound of the Baskervilles*

25

Positioned at the porous border between rational detection and atmospheric dread, Wilkie Collins’ *The Moonstone* (1868) and Arthur Conan Doyle’s *The Hound of the Baskervilles* (1902) offer fertile ground for re-reading Victorian detective fiction through the lens of speculative narrative. This paper argues that both texts stage sensory instability—of sight, sound, smell, and intuition—as narrative technologies that destabilize “consensus reality,” moving readers from epistemological wonder toward embodied horror.

While often read as foundational works of realist detective logic, both novels subtly exceed mimetic frameworks. *The Moonstone*, structured around a cursed colonial artifact, produces speculative uncertainty through competing testimonies, opium-induced altered consciousness, and the lingering spectrality of imperial extraction. The diamond becomes less an object than a sensorium: refracting colonial violence into psychological hauntings that trouble empirical knowledge. In parallel, *The Hound of the Baskervilles* mobilizes environmental perception—mist, echo, animalistic howls, phosphorescent illusion—to generate a speculative ecology where landscape itself appears sentient, threatening to collapse distinctions between natural and supernatural causality.

Drawing on speculative fiction theory (Oziewicz; Suvin) and posthuman sensory studies (Braidotti), this paper reads detection as a proto-speculative practice: an attempt to navigate realities not yet stabilized by scientific consensus. Both texts dramatize moments where empirical method falters before affective and sensory excess. In doing so, they anticipate later speculative traditions—eco-gothic, weird fiction, and slipstream—where reality is negotiated through embodied perception rather than rational mastery.

By tracing how colonial commodities (*The Moonstone*) and uncanny environments (*Baskervilles*) operate as speculative agents, this paper contributes to conversations on the limits of reality, gothic reanimations of the past, and technological anxiety surrounding knowledge production. Ultimately, these works reveal that Victorian detection already imagined worlds where truth is not discovered but sensed—flickering between wonder and horror.

After conferencing with panel in *Confound the Time: Reception in Medieval and Early Modern Studies* (24 Jan 2026), slated with the performing paper, *Dungeon-Castle and Demonic Downfall: Traumatizing Horroresque Gothicization of the Medieval Halloween*;

Z I Mahmud is aspiring to achieve *great expectations* in transnational scholarship; he seeks to acquire another Fulbright to pursue a postgraduate master's research fellowship residency in the Western world while continuing forthcoming creative-critical work in progress in Sage-ing *The Journal of Creative Aging*, *Sliding Magazine* and *The North Meridian Press*. His book chapter, *Ecocosmic and Cybernetic Femininities: Posthuman Metamorphosis in Wuthering Heights and Great Expectations*, appears in *Emerging Trends and Future Directions in Comparative Literature* from Empyrean Publications (Bombay, India). Entitled with *Remembering Otherwise: Childhood, Moral Awakening, and the Unfinished Self from Dickens to Twain* at the Sixth Annual LITCO Symposium (Purdue University), *The Poetics of Frozen Glossolalia: Mystical Grammar from Hermione's Living Marble Statue to Havisham's Cobweb-Laced Bridal Spectre* at the 8th Annual Comparative Literature Conference, organized by the Comparative Literature Graduate Association, Louisiana State University.

Marklew, Richard. Independent scholar

A Counter-Conspiracy of Corpses: Reading Daniel Borzutzky and Rachael Allen Under (Late) Fascism

What can it mean to read speculative literature under the current social-cultural and material conditions? Conditions of accelerating state and para-state violence; colonial, gender, sexual, and racial repression; the continuing erosion of welfare structures; and extreme ecological devastation and animal cruelty. From AI generated kill and capture lists fueling genocides and border violence to ecological destruction unleashing pandemics, the speculative futures we once only imagined have become our "new normal." However, it is not a temporal collapse or millennial arrival of future technologies that seems to define a blurring of the speculative and the real. Rather, it is an episteme of conspiracy and uncertainty. A constant flood of speculative possibilities competes for attention and demands we build communities around them. Daniel Borzutzky and Rachael Allen illuminate these social conditions by drawing on speculative aesthetics (body horror, gothic, surrealism). Their poetry plays a sense of the reality of violence and oppression against a secrecy inherent in how these violences are perpetrated and used to maintain social forms. Shocking moments of recognition are created in which seemingly impossible bodily mutilations and dismemberments are recognized as real. Conversely, real events and structural realities veer off into disorienting transmogrifications and surreal juxtapositions of images. Their poetry illuminates a ground of secrecy to our consensus realities. One which is cultivated as what Michael Taussig would call the public secret – or knowing what not to know. I claim that their works act as a counterconspiracy against our current conditions by punching holes through this secrecy, allowing horrors of excess and indeterminacy to burst through. These horrors play out their own conspiratorial maneuvers against forms of reduction and control. They commune with each other and exceed any internal or external bounds placed on them – images not contained in typical sequences, flesh escaping and blending with environments and things.

Richard Marklew recently completed his doctoral thesis at Freie Universität Berlin. His thesis analyzed magic and ritual aspects of intersubjectivity and corporeality in the work of Samuel Beckett, as well as critiquing the ontological foundations of concepts of

hospitality. Marklew has published essays on Paul Auster and the Phenomenology of Sickness, Phenomenological poetics, as well as the cultural history of radical movements. He is currently doing ethnographic research into the literary and aesthetic practices of radical activist groups and labor unions.

Martín González, Alessandra. University of Zaragoza, Spain

Nature Rewriting the Body: Trans-Corporeality and Posthuman Ecosystems in Nnedi Okorafor's *Lagoon*

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Taking advantage of the narrative devices of speculative fiction, in Nnedi Okorafor's *Lagoon* bodies and nature inhabit each other in a dialogic manner, thus building a posthuman continuum. The arrival of shape-shifting aliens in the Nigerian city of Lagos alters the waters, which become "teeming with ocean life" (Okorafor 84). The natural environment becomes an extension of the self, and affects bodies in return: "The longer we stay here, the more we shift and become like the people of the water" (Okorafor 252). In this way, otherness traverses nature and gets under the skin to become a catalyst of change, and there is a rewriting of the environment as inseparable from the self. Drawing on critical posthumanism (Braidotti, Ferrando), as well as notions about material feminist embodiment (Alaimo) and vulnerability studies (Daigle), this contribution will examine how Okorafor's prose challenges the nature-culture binarism. Due to this fracture, the boundaries of the self are also dissolved into a posthuman ecosystem, evoking a different kind of subjectivity which is trans-corporeal (Alaimo) and dynamic. The body is reinscribed in nature according to the notion of "affect-ability", that is, "the ability to affect and be affected" (Daigle 117). In this manner, the body becomes both an agent and recipient of nature, establishing a symbiotic relationship and blurring the frontier between human and nonhuman. As it follows, this paper will posit that nature and bodies are equally vulnerable in the face of a rapidly advancing human and environmental crisis. Okorafor reclaims their creative and transformative potential: in a world of shape-shifting creatures, the planet is also bound to shape-shift. *Lagoon* creates a fictional diegesis where the symbiotic encounter between body and planet is possible. What was perceived as alien becomes integrated (nature within bodies, aliens within society). In line with this porosity, the themes of the narration traverse its form through the choice of a non-human narrator: Udide, the cosmic spider of Igbo mythology. Ultimately, this paper will argue that Okorafor's narration weaves nature and fiction into a spiderweb that dethrones the anthropos and places it at the same level as nonhuman subjectivities, thus contributing to the envisioning of a symbiotic posthuman ecosystem.

Alessandra Martín González is a PhD candidate in the programme of English Studies at the University of Zaragoza, in cooperation with the research project "The Posthuman Wound: Subject and Agency in the North American Literature of the 21st Century". She has taken part in international congresses such as AUDEM 2024 and LIMLIT 2025. She has published in the monographic *Encadenadas a las letras* with a contribution on "Fear, Creativity and Posthumanism: the Archetype of the Female Heroine in Octavia Butler's Science Fiction". She has received collaboration grants with the departments of the University of Salamanca and the Complutense University of Madrid.

Meyers, Michelle. University of south California, U.S.A.
Challenging Consensus Reality or Reaffirming the Status Quo? The Role of Carceral Futures in the Contemporary Imagination

Nana Kwame Adjei-Brenyah's debut novel *Chain-Gang All-Stars* (2023) is set in an imagined America where convicted wards of the state are offered an alternative to death row and/or sentences longer than 25 years by participating in televised death matches under the "Criminal Action Penal Entertainment (CAPE)" program. This novel appealed both to Michelle Meyers's love of speculative fiction and to her scholarly interest in carceral justice. Her work as a creative writer is also in the realm of speculative fiction, and I have been teaching with and coordinating community engagement events for University of Southern California Dornsife's Prison Education Project since 2019.

In the wake of reading *Chain-Gang All-Stars*, she began to search out other depictions of carceral systems in recent speculative literature, including novels such as *I Keep My Exoskeletons to Myself* by Marisa Crane (2023) and *The Dream Hotel* by Laila Lalami (2025), among others.

Literary scholar Darko Suvin argues that science fiction creates spaces for "cognitive estrangement"—an awareness that the world of the story differs in some fundamental way from our current reality—through the use of a *novum*, or the logically-plausible *new thing* that creates this differentiation (examples include time travel, alien invaders, etc.)¹.

Using this framework, I hope to explore tensions in the field of literary criticism about the potential impact of these dystopian carceral representations as they relate to our contemporary world, particularly in the United States. Does Suvin's cognitive estrangement indeed enable a space for critical reflection in which potential activists are inspired by fictional cultural production ("imaginactivism," as Haran would describe it)², or, in their stubborn insistence on dystopian carceral futures that are intricately tied in with the present-day police state, are these novels actually counterproductive to the ideals of prison reform and abolition movements, engaging in a kind of "disimagination" that pushes narrow, hegemonic visions of what could be?³

Michelle Meyers is an Assistant Professor (Teaching) in the Writing Program at the University of Southern California. She received her MFA from the University of Alabama and her BA from Brown University. Meyers' teaching and research interests include

¹ Suvin, Darko, and Gerry Canavan. *Metamorphoses of Science Fiction : On the Poetics and History of a Literary Genre*. [New edition]., vol. 18, Peter Lang, 2016, <https://doi.org/10.3726/978-3-0353-0735-1>.

² Haran, Joan. "Instantiating Imaginactivism: Le Guin's *The Dispossessed* as Inspiration." *Ada: A Journal of Gender, New Media, and Technology*, No. 12., 2017, <https://doi.org/10.13016/M2GT5FH08>.

³ Avant Blachman, Daniel A.. "Prisons of the Imagination: Carceral Ideology and Race in Science Fictio"" Master of Arts (MA), Thesis, Old Dominion University, 2024, <https://doi.org/10.25777/145q-wy06>.

community engagement, service-learning, prison education, and the medical humanities, and she has presented her scholarship at conferences including the Conference on Community Writing, the Conference on College Composition and Communication, and the Northeast Modern Language Association Conference, among others. Her book chapter titled “Reexamining the War Metaphor and Narratives of Individual Culpability: How Breast Cancer Shaped My Community Engagement Pedagogy” is forthcoming later this year in the anthology *BC (Breast Cancer) in the Academy: Coalitional Survivorship for Health Advocacy*, edited by Wendy K.Z. Anderson and Tehmina Pirzada and published by Rutgers University Press. Upcoming conferences include the English and American Literature Association (EALA) Conference in Taiwan in October 2026, where Meyers will be presenting the paper “Writing With, Not About”: A Community-Engaged Pedagogical Approach to Archival Materials and Ethical Technē.

Miranda, João. University of Coimbra, Portugal

The politics of speculative media ecologies: Future-oriented science fiction and the Political Economy of Communication

Future-oriented science fiction is best approached as a speculative practice rather than a predictive genre, as it tends to interrogate the present by projecting its sociotechnical tensions and unrealized possibilities onto imagined futures (Burnam-Fink, 2015; Nicholls & Langford, 2025). Beyond anticipating individual artifacts, these narratives stage worlds in which technologies, institutions, values, and social structures are mutually constituted, opening space for reflection on the ethical and political stakes of possible futures. Such projections are far from neutral. As McLuhan (1967) and Toffler (1976) already suggested, they help make the cultural and economic consequences of innovation intelligible and, in so doing, participate in shaping which communication futures come to seem thinkable or legitimate (Ernst & Schröter, 2021; Vint, 2021). From its nineteenth-century beginnings, the genre has conceived and framed media less as singular devices or industries than as ecologies of mediation that organize visibility and power (Ghiglione, 2010; Pringle & Nicholls, 2025). However, systematic accounts of how these ecologies are imagined remain scarce, and rarely engage the political-economic logics that structure them.

This paper revisits a prior study of representations of media ecologies and sociotechnical configurations of communication in a corpus of 86 literary, film, and television narratives of futuristic science fiction published or released between 1846 and 2000, with a complementary corpus of 30 works (Miranda, 2026). It asks whether and how that typology holds when reread through the analytical lens of the Political Economy of Media and extends the analysis through comparison with a purposively selected set of works produced after the turn of the twenty-first century. Methodologically, the paper combines comparative qualitative thematic analysis with the conceptual framework of this critical tradition.

Within this framework, attention turns to how future-oriented science fiction stages dynamics such as audience commodification, platformization, data capture and monetization, automated content production, and the appropriation of cultural labor. The paper contends that, in the most layered works, these dimensions converge into

diegetic architectures in which technology and social order are co-produced, exposing the political-economic conditions under which mediation becomes an infrastructure of power and an apparatus for privatizing public reality.

João Miranda is a Professor at the Faculty of Arts and Humanities of the University of Coimbra, Portugal, where he coordinates the Bachelor's program in Journalism and Communication. He is also a researcher at the Centre for Interdisciplinary Studies - CEIS20. His research and publications focus on media regulation, ethics, transparency, and accountability, as well as the relationship between journalism and artificial intelligence. He has participated in research projects on topics such as media trust, online violence targeting journalists, and algorithmic automation in journalism.

Molina Valero, Carlos. University of Extremadura, Spain

"The Thirteenth Virtue": Holy Expediency and the Ethics of Monstrous Violence in Joe Abercrombie's *The Devils*

This paper examines Joe Abercrombie's *The Devils* as a grimdark speculative fantasy about moral exception, institutional violence, and the monstrous afterlife of religious virtue. Set in an alternative medieval Europe governed by a powerful Church and haunted by elves, demons, witches, and other nonhuman threats, the novel imagines a world in which the defence of civilisation appears to depend on agents whom civilisation itself condemns. The paper focuses on the Chapel of the Holy Expediency, the hidden "thirteenth" chapel within the Celestial Palace, as the novel's central ethical and symbolic device. Unlike the public cult of the Twelve Virtues, Holy Expediency names the secret principle that allows the Church to suspend its own moral law to preserve its authority.

The author argues that Abercrombie's monstrous violence is not simply a grimdark inversion of heroic fantasy. Rather, it functions as a speculative test of institutional morality: what happens when virtue survives only by using the very bodies, methods, and forces it defines as evil? Through Brother Diaz's reluctant appointment and Cardinal Zizka's rhetoric of necessity, the novel exposes the instability of moral binaries such as sacred/profane, human/monster, good/evil, and salvation/damnation. The "devils" of the title thus become both weapons and ethical irritants: they reveal that the Church's claim to purity depends upon a hidden infrastructure of impurity.

By reading Holy Expediency as a speculative technology of power, this paper connects Abercrombie's grimdark medievalism to broader debates about posthuman ethics, religious violence, and the politics of emergency. *The Devils* stages a world beyond consensus reality in which monstrosity is not outside the moral order but constitutive of it. Its horror lies less in the existence of monsters than in the institutional logic that makes them necessary.

Carlos Molina Valero is a PhD candidate in English Literature at the University of Extremadura, Spain. He holds degrees in Classics from the University of Murcia, English Language and Literature from the University of Salamanca, and Archaeology from Complutense University of Madrid. He has been a visiting scholar at several institutions

in Europe and the United States, including University College London, the University of Vienna, and Harvard University. He has taught at the University of Salamanca, the University of Missouri in Madrid, and the University of Murcia, and currently serves as a substitute lecturer at the University of Extremadura. His doctoral research focuses on intertextuality in early modern English literature, with particular emphasis on sixteenth-century authors and prose fiction. Beyond his doctoral project, he is also interested in the analysis of speculative fiction, a field to which he is drawn both as a scholar and as an avid reader.

Muci, Martina. University of Bari Aldo Moro, Italy

Reworlding Consensus Reality through Indigenous Speculative Fiction: *Empire of Wild* as a Decolonial Practice of Epistemic Sovereignty

This paper aims to problematise the epistemological foundations of *consensus reality from a decolonial perspective, conceptualised as a historically situated* narrative emerging from what Walter Dignolo defines as ‘egopolitics of knowledge’ (2009, p. 176), whereby Western discourse positions itself as the site of universal truth while marginalising other onto-epistemological systems. In contrast to settler consensus reality, contemporary Indigeneity articulates a radically different ontological horizon in which relationality, ceremony, and land-based knowledges are not symbolic but constitutive of Native Americans’ holistic engagement with their intellectual, political, artistic and spiritual life (Coulthard 2014; Simpson 2017). In this sense, spirits are not metaphorical devices but ontologically grounded presences, land exceeds property regimes, and storytelling functions not as fiction but as (Hi)story and living memory (Justice 2018). This contribution therefore argues that speculative work, mobilised within Indigenous discursive practices, operates beyond regimes of truth not merely as an epistemological stance or an ontological given, but as a political act that strongly resonates with what Martineau and Ritskes (2014) term ‘fugitive Indigeneity’ – Indigenous narratives that enact epistemic sovereignty by refusing colonial frameworks of recognition. This argument is explored through *Empire of Wild* by award-winning Métis author and Nation of Ontario citizen Cherie Dimaline (2019) as a paradigmatic case of Indigenous speculative fiction. The novel reworks the Rougarou myth within contemporary settler-colonial formations, subverting Western genre categories such as horror and the monstrous. Rather than staging alterity as a threat, Dimaline re-centres Indigenous cosmologies in which the monstrous signals disrupted relationality under neocolonial oppression, particularly the gendered and sexual violence through which the ‘coloniality of gender’ (Lugones 2023) is enacted. In doing so, *Empire of Wild* unsettles the epistemic authority of consensus reality and demonstrates how Indigenous narrative praxis contributes to ongoing debates on speculative fiction as a site of political reclaim, emphasising its decolonial potential to pluralise reality systems.

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Martina Muci is a Ph.D. candidate in World Literature and Postcolonial Studies at the Department of Political Science, University of Bari Aldo Moro. She was previously offered an unfunded Ph.D. position by the Department of English Literature at the University of Birmingham, UK. She holds a Bachelor's degree in Linguistic and Cultural Mediation from the University for Foreigners of Siena, and a Master's degree in Modern, Comparative, and Postcolonial Literatures from the University of Bologna, both awarded with honours. Her research interests hinge on contemporary literature as an interdiscursive practice which can make narratives take on the role of new cultural tropes. Her first peer-reviewed article, published in issue 7/2025 "Intelligenze Alternative. Forme e Pratiche delle Risorgenze Indigene Globali" appeared in the interdisciplinary journal ECHO. She contributed to various literary magazines and two poetry anthologies; *Coreografie di un lessico caro* (Giovane Holden Edizioni 2025) is her debut poetry collection.

Munõz Andrés, Patricia. University of Salamanca, Spain

Between Magic and Meaning: Narrative Identification and Hybrid Identity in Speculative Children's Literature

This paper explores the role of speculative children's literature in shaping how young readers engage with identity, belonging, and language in early English as a Foreign Language contexts. Focusing on the narrative worlds of Isadora Moon and Mirabelle, it proposes a theoretical framework in which hybrid fictional identities create a space where the boundaries between reality and imagination are productively blurred.

Situated within speculative narratives that merge the ordinary with the magical, these protagonists embody forms of in-between identity that resonate with young learners negotiating multiple linguistic and cultural systems. Their experiences of rule following and rule breaking, belonging and difference, allow readers to explore alternative ways of being while remaining grounded in familiar social worlds. In this sense, speculative childhood operates as a site where identity is not fixed but continuously constructed through narrative engagement.

The paper introduces the concept of narrative identification as linguistic scaffolding, suggesting that emotional alignment with hybrid characters encourages not only reading engagement but also the emergence of voice in writing and oral expression. Through identification, learners move from observing fictional experiences to

reimagining and articulating their own, using language as a means of exploring possibility rather than merely reproducing form. By positioning speculative children's literature as a space of transformation rather than simple representation, this paper contributes to broader discussions on how narratives challenge consensus reality and open alternative frameworks for understanding self and language. It also outlines how these insights can inform early language teaching, while inviting further exploration of the relationship between imagination, identity, and linguistic development.

Patricia Muñoz Andrés is a Profesor Ayudante Doctor in the Department of English at the University of Salamanca (Spain), where she teaches Oral Communication, Planning for Effective Teaching, and English for Young Learners at the Teacher Training School (Zamora Campus). She also coordinates the English Track and international teaching placements, including the Coventry (UK) programme. Her research focuses on TESOL, second language acquisition, and the use of children's and young adult literature in language education, with particular attention to speculative narratives such as witch lit and hopepunk. Her recent work explores how character-driven stories support reading, writing, and identity development in early EFL contexts. She has presented her research at national and international conferences and has taught in higher education in the United States, including at the University of Wisconsin–Milwaukee and Carthage College. She also brings industry experience directing translation and localization teams, which informs her approach to language education and teacher training. This combined academic and international teaching experience informs her approach to language education and teacher training.

Poniatyszyn, Kajetan. University of Wrocław, Poland

Fictional Places, Real Problems: Post-Industrial Ruins in Contemporary Polish and American Weird Fiction (Based on Short Stories by Jakub Bielawski and Thomas Ligotti)

The aim of this presentation is to analyze how descriptions of post-industrial ruins enable authors of weird fiction (Jakub Bielawski and Thomas Ligotti) to address issues relating to socio-political realities. Analysis will be conducted using selected methods of cultural anthropology, such as Marc Auge's liminal spaces (1995), ruin studies (Edensor 2005) and genre studies (Weinstock 2016). Weird fiction is a literary genre that emerged in late XIX century with Artur Machen, Algernon Blackwood and Howard Phillips Lovecraft among its most recognized early authors (Joshi 1990). Writings of Ligotti, published in 80s and 90s, were crucial from the perspective of the emerging New Weird genre (Noys, Murphy 2016). Genre is present in Polish XXI-st century popular literature field, with its most prominent authors being Wojciech Guńia, Jakub Bielawski and Anna Maria Wybraniec.

Both Ligotti and Bielawski, despite representing different literary traditions, which is also reflected in the countries where their stories are set, describe abandoned post-industrial buildings. These spaces are often linked to social problems specific to particular regions, such as Lower Silesia in Poland and the Rust Belt in the United States. These regions share similar socio-political conditions, including urban decay, ongoing depopulation, and the decline of heavy industry as a result of neoliberal capitalist policies. The aesthetic and speculative dimensions of ruins (as reminders of alternative futures) play

a crucial role in shaping the representation of social problems in weird fiction. A comparison of selected texts by Bielawski and Ligotti will demonstrate similarities between Polish and American weird fiction and highlight the socially engaged character of both the genre and its spatial imaginarium.

Kajetan Poniatyszyn is a BA and MA graduate of the Institute of Polish Studies (University of Wrocław), and is currently doing his PhD in Literary Studies. The topic of the doctoral thesis: *Weirding the World: Genesis and Evolution of Contemporary Polish Weird Fiction (1989–2025)*. He is PhD student in the Department of Folk, Popular and Children's Literature (Institute of Polish Studies, Faculty of Letters, University of Wrocław), literary critic and scholar. His current academic interests include place studies, speculative fiction, sociology of literature and genre studies, especially weird fiction, New Weird and solarpunk. Recent publications: Poniatyszyn, K. (2025). Terminological and Genological Notes on Weird Fiction and Horror. *The Problems of Literary Genres*, 68(1), 53–71. <https://doi.org/10.26485/ZRL/2025/68.1/5> (PL); Poniatyszyn, K. (2025). Oneirism as a Strategy of Creating an Uncanny Space in the Latest Polish Weird Fiction Literature. *Spaces of Theory*, 44 (44), 41–56. <https://doi.org/10.14746/pt.2025.44.2> (PL). ORCID: 0000000245605615.

Purcell Sjölund, Anita and Farkas, Zita. Dalarna University, Sweden

Becoming-With at the Edge of the Human: Sympoiesis, Posthuman Ethics, and Transhuman Identity in Speculative Fiction

Within the ideological context of transhumanism, speculative fiction deals with 'What if?' by pushing current global trends and developments into realms defying empirical materialism. Ai Jiang's transhuman postapocalyptic novelette *I am AI* explores the consequences of technological human augmentation through the protagonist ghostwriter Ai who, for the sake of increased productivity, slowly replaces her body parts, including her heart, with artificial technology. She falls into a philosophical conundrum in which she questions her identity and personhood as Ai or as A.I. Focussing on an analogue perspective, the Queer steampunk horror *A Botanical Daughter* by Noah Medlock looks at eco-transhumanism within a mycological cultural turn, as seen in popular cultural production. Medlock's novel is about taxidermist Simon and botanist Gregor who live together in solitude on the edge of Victorian London society. They possess a strange fungus showing signs of intellect, and Gregor works to create true intelligent life from plant matter out of which the result is a half fungal human female called Chloe. These literary texts offer a type of protagonist echoing Haraway's Chthulucene that heralds human and nonhuman as being linked in tentacular practices. A comparative analysis of *I am AI* and *A Botanical Daughter* show their exploration of the entanglement of "myriad temporalities and spatialities and myriad intra-active entities-inassemblages—including the more-than-human, other-than-human, inhuman, and human-ashumus" (Haraway, 101). These literary texts challenge auto-poiesis or the self-human-making machine of history (Haraway, 118) by instead proposing sympoiesis, namely the making-with or "becoming-with" Haraway, 119). Stories of making with or becoming-with are exemplified through the marginalised protagonists in *I am AI* and *A Botanical Daughter*. These texts first explore how human existence is measured regarding exclusivity or inclusivity which is reminiscent of Agamben's discussion of the

homo sacre as either sacred or accursed. However, being on the edge of existence forces invention and creation in which new forms of knowledge and social relations are envisioned. As briefly summarised so far, these literary texts offer controversial perspectives to current ecological, political, and ethnic standards in our contemporary times to ensure that we do not end up living the forms of apocalypse projected in speculative fiction.

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Anita Purcell-Sjölund is a researcher in the fields of indigenous studies, literature studies, as well as film and media studies. She holds a doctorate in Media Studies and Cultural Studies from Goldsmiths College, University of London along with degrees in literature, indigenous studies, and political sociology from universities in New Zealand and Sweden. She is also a lecturer at Dalarna University, Sweden and works in the media as a journalist.

Zita Farkas is a researcher in the fields of gender and queer studies, literature studies, as well as film and digital (literature) studies. She holds a doctorate in Contemporary Women's Writing from University of York along with degrees in English Literature and Gender Studies from universities in Hungary. She is currently a Senior Lecturer in English Literature at Malmö University and a Lecturer in English at Dalarna University, Sweden.

Papalia, Lorenza. University of Birmingham, The United Kingdom

Beyond the Human Sensorium: Extended Consciousness and the Weird in Algernon Blackwood

This paper examines how weird fiction functions as a speculative mode that destabilizes “consensus reality” by reimagining consciousness as extending beyond the human. Focusing on the work of Algernon Blackwood (1869-1951), I argue that his narratives anticipate key concerns of contemporary speculative fiction and posthumanist theory by presenting consciousness as distributed across human and nonhuman domains.

Speculative fiction, as described by Margaret Atwood, concerns what “could happen,” while Marek Oziwicz frames it as a fluid “supercategory” that resists fixed boundaries. Blackwood’s weird fiction operates precisely within this instability. His stories do not merely depict supernatural events or presences; rather, they stage encounters in which perception itself becomes unreliable, and the distinction between inner and outer worlds collapses.

Across his fiction, Blackwood explores “extended consciousness” through five interrelated domains that I investigate in my work: the occult, psychical research, the plant kingdom, animal life, and the fourth dimension. In each case, human awareness is

shown to be partial and permeable. Forests, for instance, are not passive settings but active presences that absorb and reshape human identity. Similarly, encounters with animals and unseen forces challenge the assumption that consciousness is exclusively human, opening speculative thresholds toward radically decentered modes of perception.

Engaging with Rosi Braidotti's concept of the posthuman subject, this paper suggests that Blackwood's fiction articulates a relational ontology in which agency is shared across a network of beings. These moments of expanded perception oscillate between wonder and horror, revealing both the allure and the threat of losing the boundaries of the self, and foregrounding an ethics of interconnection.

Blackwood's work demonstrates how speculative narratives can reconfigure the limits of reality, inviting us to imagine modes of being that exceed the human and to confront the instability of consciousness itself, particularly in the context of ecological crisis and shifting ontological paradigms.

Lorenza Papalia is a postgraduate researcher in English Literature at the University of Birmingham. Her research focuses on supernatural fiction, ecoGothic, occultism, and psychical research in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. Her current thesis examines the representation of otherworldly phenomena in the works of Algernon Blackwood, with particular attention to spectrality, perception, and non-human agency. Further, her current project investigates also how literary form mediates human and nonhuman encounters. She is particularly interested in ecocritical studies and the ecogothic, exploring how narratives engage with non-human environments, environmental anxiety, and the representation of more-than-human agency in literary and cultural texts. Her work is informed by interdisciplinary approaches, drawing on posthumanist theory, critical animal studies, and environmental humanities. She has presented her research at international conferences and is interested in the intersections between weird fiction, speculative narratives, and philosophical conceptions of consciousness and reality, across diverse historical and cultural contexts.

Pascoal, Sara and Mesquita, Rosa. Porto Accounting and Business School, Portugal
From Borges' Labyrinth to Benjamin's Ruin: Speculative Space in Tarkovsky's *Stalker*

This paper examines Andrei Tarkovsky's film *Stalker* (1979) as a paradigmatical work of speculative cinema that deconstructs "consensus reality" through the interconnected figures of the labyrinth and the ruin. Set in the Zone's indeterminate space, *Stalker* creates a speculative atmosphere that rejects rational mapping, causal explanation, and narrative closure in favour of errancy, hesitation, and sensory doubt.

Drawing on Jorge Luis Borges's concept of the labyrinth as an infinite, acented, and self-reflexive structure, the study argues that the Zone functions as a borgesian labyrinth without a definite center or a guaranteed exit. The journey becomes an existential quest, as the movement within this area is controlled by repetition, deviation, and loss of direction rather than mastery or advancement. At the center of the Zone, the promised

Room functions as a paradoxical hub: a place of unquenchable desire whose fulfilment is perpetually postponed, upending the logic of revelation and meaning itself.

Simultaneously, the Zone is shaped by a landscape of ruins that recalls Walter Benjamin's philosophy of history. Industrial debris, abandoned infrastructures, and flooded interiors are read not as remnants of a closed past, but as dialectical images in which multiple temporalities collide. These ruins suspend historical linearity and open a constellation of unrealised futures, situating *Stalker* within a speculative mode that oscillates between wonder and unease, hope and catastrophe.

This paper argues that *Stalker* expresses a speculative ethics based on care, attention, and the rejection of instrumental reason by fusing the Benjaminian ruin with the Borgesian labyrinth. Tarkovsky's film thus emerges as a powerful speculative narrative that imagines alternative ways of inhabiting unstable worlds, not by projecting technological futures or staging dystopian spectacles, but by foregrounding ruin, temporal delay, and a sustained questioning of reality itself.

Sara Pascoal is a lecturer and researcher in communication and cultural studies at ISCAP – Polytechnic of Porto, where she has been teaching since 1997. She holds a PhD in Romance Languages and Literatures, a Master's degree in Portuguese Culture, and a Bachelor's degree in Modern Languages and Literatures (Portuguese/French). Her work explores the intersections between cultural memory, narrative practices, heritage, and tourism, focusing on how storytelling, visual culture, and travel narratives shape representations of place, identity, and collective memory. She has published on topics such as semiotics, memory studies, and cultural heritage, with particular attention to Iberian contexts. Her recent work examines narrative and communicative practices as forms of cultural mediation that transform lived experiences into shared heritage. Her research contributes to interdisciplinary debates on memory, heritage representation, and the cultural dynamics of place, aligning with projects that explore storytelling as a vehicle for cultural knowledge and social memory.

Rosa Mesquita

She holds a PhD in Romance Literatures and Cultures, specialising in Portuguese Literature, from the Faculty of Arts and Humanities of the University of Porto. Her doctoral thesis, *Luís Miguel Nava, Reader of Eugénio de Andrade: Two Poetics in Dialogue*, explores the silent voices that resonate between different modes of writing and reading. She is currently a secondary school teacher of Portuguese. Until 2024, she taught French Language I, II and III at ISAG – European Business School. She has also taught Communication Theory, Textual Practices, Argumentation Theory, and Expression Techniques at ISCAP – Porto Accounting and Business School, as well as *Literature and Visitors* within a postgraduate programme in Literary Tourism at the Porto School of Hospitality and Tourism. She has collaborated as an external researcher with the Intermedialities research group at the Institute for Comparative Literature Margarida Losa (University of Porto) and is currently a member of the Centre for Intercultural Studies (ISCAP). Her research focuses on 20th- and 21st-century Portuguese poetry and its intersections with cinema, painting, and music, as well as

creative writing and digital cultures. She published her first poetry book, *Mar em mim*, in 2023 and *Ilumina-me*, in 2025.

Pereyra, Carmen. Friedrich Schiller University Jena, Germany

The Horror of the Ongoing: Indigenous Extinction, Colonial Time, and the Limits of Narrative Frame in Joca Reiners Terrón's *A morte e o meteoro*

This paper analyses how horror in Joca Reiners Terrón's novel *A morte e o meteoro* appears not only a generic and stylistic marker but as a temporal and structural condition. The impending extinction of the Kaajapukugi, who have seen their living space destroyed and, with it, their cosmogony and spiritual life, is not presented as a future or "critical" event that produces a rupture in historical time, but as the continuation of a process that began with the conquest: not a past horror, but an ongoing one. The formal narrative strategies of the novel are central to my analysis. Drawing on Raffaella Baccolini's theorization of genre blurring in critical dystopia, the paper examines how the novel — through its use of the Gothic and the adventure novel, and through an explicit dialogue with Joseph Conrad's *Heart of Darkness*— gives form to colonial catastrophe in the present and offers resistance to prevailing ideology of modernity and its understanding of progressive linear time. The paper further analyses the narrative framing strategy that Terrón employs to recount the experiences of the Kaajapakugi tribe: presented as a video testimony by Boaventura, a *sertanista* who died under suspicious circumstances, mediated by the narration of a Mexican government bureaucrat and interrupted by an institutional framework, represented by the police. Under these narrative conditions, the tribe remains, in Édouard Glissant's sense, opaque; irreducible to the institutional account through which the novel attempts to narrate it. This formal opacity, I will argue, also constitutes the horror. Not the horror of the monstrous, but rather the structural horror of a catastrophe that cannot be fully witnessed, narrated, or resolved within the frameworks produced by Modernity. In this sense, the novel offers a chronotope of permanent colonial crisis: a narrative organisation in which the destruction of the Amazon, the genocide of indigenous peoples, and the original violence of the conquest do not appear as sequential historical events but as dimensions of a continuous present. Colonial time, the novel insists, does not pass.

Carmen Pereyra holds a MA in Anthropology from the University of Leipzig and a BA in Modern Literature, Literary Theory and Analysis and a MA on Latin American Literature from the University of Buenos Aires. This analysis is developed within the broader framework of a doctoral dissertation on social imaginaries of time and crisis in contemporary Latin American dystopian fiction, pursued as part of the Research School of the Imaginamics Cluster of Excellence at Friedrich Schiller University Jena.

Quintairos-Soliño, Alba. University of Zaragoza, Spain

Bordering in Margaret Atwood's *The Handmaid's Tale*: An Approach to the Text-Image Relationship through Speculative Boundaries

Sendhardt highlights the necessity of analysing not only existing borders, but also the sociological process behind their creation and evolution — a phenomenon better known

as “bordering”—. Therefore, two types of borders must be differentiated: static borders—those physical, visible, and material delimitations acting as barriers (such as rivers, mountains, seas, walls, etc.)— and dynamic borders—social constructions that vary according to cultural, political and economic practices— (26). Moreover, dynamic borders can be functional or symbolic, depending on what social constructions are involved. In this context, it can be argued that Margaret Atwood’s *The Handmaid’s Tale* (1985) is first and foremost a novel about bordering. This is due to the fact that every element in the story affects or is affected by physical and symbolic spaces as well as the bordering processes they entail. What is more, the very creation of *The Handmaid’s Tale* derives from the opposition of reality and imagination and Atwood’s attempt to blur the boundaries between both notions: as the author puts it, the dystopian world she describes is nothing but the agglomeration of uncanny, yet real historical events affecting—or having affected— women all around the world. Thus, Atwood is not only imagining a dystopian future for the United States of America but also reminding her readers that this dystopia is not far-fetched, as all the unsettling elements of this story have already happened at some point. Furthermore, the way in which the novel is narrated defamiliarizes the current world for the readers, who have to make the effort to connect what they know with what it is being implied in the story. This also introduces an unexpected boundary that must be tackled when approaching *The Handmaid’s Tale*. All in all, this research aims at exploring the inexorable relationship between text and (mental) images through the analysis of physical and symbolic bordering within Margaret Atwood’s *The Handmaid’s Tale*.

Alba Quintairos-Soliño is an associate lecturer in the Department of Languages at Centro Universitario de la Defensa de Zaragoza (University of Zaragoza, Spain), and a member of the Translation & Paratranslation Research Group (University of Vigo, Spain), the Research Group in Language, Discourse, Culture and Defense (CUD Zaragoza) and the Instituto de investigación Lingua (UVigo). Doctor in Translation & Paratranslation (UVigo), she also holds a degree in Translation and Interpreting (UVigo) and a master’s degree in East Asian Studies (U. of Salamanca), which she further complemented with a MA in Literature in English (Dalarna University, Sweden). Her research involves the paratranslation of the text-image relationship, as well as the analysis of Othering dynamics represented in Pop Culture.

Ramos-Stokes, Rodrigo. University of Aveiro, Portugal
Fëanor’s Egotism and Alienation in J. R. R. Tolkien’s *The Silmarillion*

This paper analyses Fëanor’s egotism and alienation in *The Silmarillion* through discourses of masculinity, arguing that his character exemplifies a destructive and hypermasculine model of power. As the most gifted of the Noldor, celebrated as linguist, smith, and creator of the Silmarils and the Palantíri, Fëanor embodies extraordinary creative authority, yet these capacities are inseparable from possessiveness, pride, and entitlement. His oath to recover the Silmarils and avenge his father after Morgoth’s theft and violence initiates a pattern in which masculine self-assertion overrides kinship, ethical restraint, and communal responsibility. The paper argues that Fëanor enacts a form of hypermasculinity grounded in domination, mastery, and refusal of limitation, visible in his belief that his power rivals that of the Valar and in his abandonment of

kingdom, wife, and obligations in pursuit of vengeance. Drawing on Todd W. Reeser's theorisation of masculinity, Fëanor is read as embodying a rigid masculine ideal associated with strength, control, hardness, and self-will (Reeser: 2010, p. 1). However, rather than affirming these traits as heroic, Tolkien exposes their catastrophic consequences. Rage, egotism, and the imposition of will become sources of alienation and historical ruin, setting in motion violence that shapes the First Age. The study further argues that Tolkien differentiates between ethically legitimate and distorted masculinities, complicating inherited heroic ideals rather than simply reproducing them. Fëanor serves as a foundational example of masculine excess in the legendarium, illustrating how Tolkien critiques not masculinity itself but forms of masculine power corrupted by domination, possessiveness, and refusal of restraint. Through Fëanor, Tolkien establishes an early model of how authority detached from ethical responsibility becomes self-destructive, making his character central to understanding the relationship between masculinity, power, and moral failure in the legendarium.

Rodrigo Ramos worked as an expatriate English teacher in Timor-Leste from February 2024 to December 2025. He served as English Coordinator and Teacher at a secondary school in Tábor, Czech Republic, from August 2021 to December 2023. From March 2020 to July 2021, he worked as a Portuguese language teacher at INFORDEPE in Díli, Timor-Leste. He was an English Teacher (Cursos Livres) in the Department of Languages and Cultures at the University of Aveiro from September 2019 to March 2020. Between February 2019 and August 2019, he taught English at the Department of Arts, Languages and Communication at the University of Trás-Os-Montes e Alto Douro. From 7 July 2014 to 15 August 2017, he worked as an EFL teacher for MLI International Schools, primarily in Edinburgh, London, Portsmouth and Chelmsford.

Ramos, Tiago. NOVA University, Portugal

The Ghost in the Early Machine: Speculative Ancestry and Technological Anxiety from Méliès to AI

Long before the category was theorized by writers such as Robert A. Heinlein or reframed by Margaret Atwood, early film invited audiences to confront moving images that animated the inanimate, destabilized perception, and challenged "consensus reality." The wonder frequently described by early spectators was not only technological astonishment but also an encounter with speculative scenarios staged through the cinematic apparatus. At the center of this discussion is *Gugusse et l'Automate* (1897), a film by George Méliès rediscovered in 2025. In this trick film, the clown Gugusse constructs an automaton that turns against its creator. This narrative can be read as an early cinematic reflection on mechanical life, agency, and the unstable boundary between human and technological actors. Viewed from the present, *Gugusse et l'Automate* resonates uncannily with contemporary anxieties surrounding artificial intelligence and technological autonomy. This resonance does not imply prophetic intent – rather, it demonstrates how speculative narratives generate images that acquire renewed relevance across historical moments. What was speculative in 1897 becomes speculative again in 2025, as new technological contexts invite new readings from present audiences, that recognize in the film their own concerns. Reframing this film through the lenses of speculative fiction demonstrates how cinema functioned,

from its inception, as a medium for imagining technological futures and interrogating the limits of reality, media, and the human.

Tiago Ramos is a PhD student in Communication Sciences, specializing in Cinema and Television, at the Faculty of Social Sciences and Humanities of NOVA University Lisbon. He was awarded a PhD Scholarship by the Foundation for Science and Technology. He holds a master's degree in Comparative Studies from the Faculty of Arts and Humanities of the University of Lisbon. During his master's degree, he carried out a research project entitled "Aquém e Além de Si: Os Diários de Jonas Mekas". Tiago Ramos has also published several scientific articles in national and international academic journals, as well as given several presentations at both national and international conferences.

Richardson, Reed. Independent scholar

Simplicity demands too great a sacrifice: Revisiting the ideological discourse of *The Queen of the Damned* for a transfeminist present

Should we kill all men? That's the question asked—and intensely debated—in Anne Rice's 1988 gothic horror novel *The Queen of the Damned*. The ancient vampire Akasha, finding men responsible for thousands of years of human violence, sets out to exterminate 90% of the male population, and create herself as the mother goddess of a new epoch. This apocalypse adventure novel and vampire horror story is also a philosophical dialogue, debating the ethical implications of Akasha's totalizing strategy. Meanwhile, the past few years have seen a meteoric rise in those who espouse classically misogynistic talking points under pseudo-feminist aesthetics, arguing for the existence of inborn "divine feminine" traits, and promising female liberation if women just acknowledge and submit to their innate, biological, womanly characteristics.

This paper examines and defines the ideology of QOTD, with an eye toward its contemporary feminist discourse and reception, as well as the current state of gender essentialist rhetoric. I pay particular attention to the "divine feminine", both as a literary trope and as a social media trend, and the invocation of gender essentialism by ostensibly pro-woman actors. Ultimately, I take a transfeminist approach to ask what Rice's dialogues can tell us about navigating an obviously violent and patriarchal world without being recruited into advancing a conservative agenda. Akasha's approach is seductive to the disaffected, a "fix everything" button, impossibly simple. But gender essentialism is at odds with a feminist future. As one of Rice's vampires argues: "simplicity demands too great a sacrifice."

Reed Richardson is a writer and theatre artist based in Brooklyn, New York. His research interests surround trans and queer studies, American literature, Shakespeare, drama, and performance studies. He holds a degree in Literatures in English from Bryn Mawr College, and his prose and poetry has been published in PRISM International, Paranoid Tree, and elsewhere.

Rosende Pérez, Aida. University of Vigo, Spain

Breathing Underwater: Speculative Ontologies and the Black Aquatic in Rivers Solomon's *The Deep*

This paper examines Rivers Solomon's novella *The Deep* (2019) through the lens of Rinaldo Walcott's conceptualization of the "Black Aquatic": that "ambiguous and ambivalent relationship that Black people hold to bodies of water" (2021, 65). For Walcott, what ultimately defines the Black Aquatic is an unresolved tension between "liquidity"—as simultaneously the "context" in which Blackness "begins" (66) and also a conceivable ecology for "the birth of black possibility" (66)—and "liquidation" as "a synonym for death" (66) and even extinction. It is precisely this tension that lies at the core of Solomon's speculative narrative in *The Deep* and, particularly, in faer vision of the wajinru. These are aquatic descendants of pregnant enslaved women thrown overboard slave ships during the Middle Passage, merfolk who exist "in the wake" (Sharpe 2016, 18) and are literally birthed by it. In this paper, I read these water-breathing creatures as embodiment, and perhaps "resolution" (Walcott 2021, 70) and "reinvention" (71), of the ontological tensions and overlapping temporalities of the Black Aquatic—their very existence interrupting the expected outcome of drowning and suffocation of the Black (female) body, and ushering forth "new potentialities that come into being" (Walcott 2021, 66). Through this reading, I will contend that in *The Deep*, Solomon speculates on the plausibility of evolutionary mutations that would enable the birth and breath of different modes of be(com)ing outside or without the unbreathable, deadly atmospheres generated by intersecting patriarchy, heteronormativity, anthropocentrism, racism, (neo)colonialism, and neoliberal capitalism.

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Aida Rosende Pérez is Associate Professor in English at the University of Vigo (Spain). She is a researcher in the Consolidated Research Group BIFEGA (Literary, Cultural, and Translation Studies), serving as principal investigator for the Feminisms and Resistance line. She is also a researcher at the Interuniversity Research Center for Atlantic Cultural Landscapes (CISPAC). She specializes in feminist theory and gender studies applied to the critical analysis of literary and audiovisual texts in the Englishspeaking world. Her work pays special attention to literary and cultural representations of women's transnational displacements, particularly those across the Atlantic Ocean or in/to countries washed by its shores, mainly Ireland and the USA. She is currently working on black feminist theories of survival through the study of breathing as a material process and poetic-aesthetic resource with profound ethical and political implications in the work of black women authors and filmmakers. She is a member of the research project *Communitas/Immunitas: Relational Ontologies in Atlantic Anglophone Cultures of the 21st Century*, funded by the Spanish Ministry of Science Education and Universities (2023 - 2026, PID2022-136904NB-I00).

Saludes Zanfaño, Marta I. University of Salamanca, Spain

Making Food Systems Visible: More-Than-Human Narratives for Ecological Literacy in Teacher Education

Food production sustains everyday life, yet the ecological relationships that make it possible often remain invisible within educational contexts. While biodiversity and sustainability have become central themes in contemporary education, the agroecosystems that connect soils, seeds, pollinators, crops, animals, water, technologies, and people rarely occupy a central place in how these issues are taught. As a result, many future teachers encounter biodiversity as an abstract concept rather than as a living network of relationships that also shapes the food systems on which societies depend.

This presentation emerges from *Al ritmo de la granja* ("At the Rhythm of the Farm"), a service-learning initiative developed in teacher education and inspired by ongoing concerns about the educational invisibility of the agro-food sector. Rather than approaching agriculture solely through production, economics, or environmental impact, the project invites participants to view farms as more-than-human communities in which diverse forms of life coexist and depend upon one another.

Drawing on perspectives from more-than-human ecologies and speculative pedagogies, the presentation explores how storytelling can help make these relationships visible. Through imagined diaries of seeds, narratives voiced by soils and pollinators, and speculative futures for agricultural landscapes facing climate change, participants are encouraged to engage with food systems from perspectives that move beyond the exclusively human viewpoint.

By bringing agroecosystems into discussions of more-than-human ecologies, this contribution highlights the potential of speculative narratives to foster ecological literacy and to reconnect biodiversity, food systems, and rural sustainability within teacher education.

Marta I. Saludes Zanfaño is a lecturer in Science Education at the University of Salamanca (Spain). Her work brings together sustainable agriculture, teacher education, and environmental learning, drawing on both academic research and practical experience in the agricultural sector. Interested in the stories that connect people to the landscapes that feed them, she collaborates with rural communities and agricultural organisations to develop educational initiatives that promote ecological literacy, sustainability, and engagement with food systems. Her current work explores agroecosystems as spaces for learning through service-learning, place-based education, and more-than-human perspectives.

Saraiva, Hélia. University of Aveiro, Portugal

Disability, salutogenesis, and (post)human futures: A Comparative study of Philip K. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* and Andromeda Romano-Lax's *Plum Rains*

The aim of this study is to comparatively analyze representations of disability and salutogenic processes in Philip K. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968) and Andromeda Romano Lax's *Plum Rains* (2018). Drawing on critical disability studies, posthumanism, and salutogenesis theory (Antonovsky, 1987), it examines how some aspects of both novels reconfigure notions of (post)humanity amid technological acceleration, ecological crisis, and shifting bodily norms. Theoretically, the work builds on Garland-Thomson's cultural model of disability, while critiquing the "narrative of cure" (Clare, 2017; Kafer, 2013; Sheppard, 2025), in favor of Siebers's aesthetics of disability and Kafer's crip futures – emphasizing vulnerability, interdependence, and relational coexistence over compulsory able-bodiedness.

A close comparative reading structured is presented around three axes: (1) disability as cultural construct, (2) salutogenic mechanisms in precarity and hybridization, and (3) ethical reconfigurations of normativity and otherness. The analysis shows how both texts challenge anthropocentrism and ableism. Dick critiques eugenics through characters like John Isidore and the Nexus-6 androids, while Romano-Lax explores aging, trauma, and AI care in a near-future setting. In both cases, salutogenesis arises from relational practices of care, empathy, and shared storytelling rather than biomedical normalization.

This study concludes that speculative fiction holds transgressive power to reimagine the "good life," offering inclusive models of (post)human coexistence based on somatic diversity, accessibility, and community, despite lingering anthropocentric tensions.

Hélia Saraiva teaches accessibility and has over 8 years of experience teaching Spanish. She was part of the teaching staff of the Postgraduate Program in Astrotourism at the Higher Institute of Business and Tourism. She is a columnist for *Pressenza*, researcher at Centre for African Studies of the University of Porto and a member of the Portuguese Association for Diversity and Inclusion. She holds a degree in Comparative Literature and a master's degree in Anglo-American Studies from the University of Porto. She completed her doctoral studies in Information Science at the University of Fernando Pessoa and has entered a new doctoral program in Literary Studies at the University of Aveiro. She has been a speaker at international and national conferences. Two of her main articles are: "Estudos sobre as Pessoas com Capacidades Restringidas e o ensino das ciências físicas: Contributos compósitos para desafios inclusivos" and "Microaggressions represented in identity and imaginary of disability in museums".

Schnakovszky, Stefania. Ovidius University of Constanța, Romania

Negotiating Jewish Identity Between Memory and Imagination: Post-Holocaust Narratives in Anglophone Literature

This paper explores the construction of Jewish identity in Anglophone post-Holocaust literature through the lens of memory, trauma, and speculative imagination. While traditionally associated with realism and testimonial forms, post-Holocaust narratives often employ fragmented structures, symbolic language, and imaginative reconfigurations of memory that move beyond strict representations of historical reality.

Drawing on trauma theory and Critical Discourse Analysis, the study examines how identity is articulated not as a fixed category but as a dynamic process shaped by narrative strategies and cultural negotiation. Particular attention is given to the works of Adrienne Rich and Emma Lazarus, whose writing reflects different historical moments while engaging with similar tensions between belonging, displacement, and identity formation.

The paper argues that these texts operate within a broader framework of speculative thinking, where memory is not only recalled but reimagined. By challenging linear temporality and stable identity categories, they open up alternative ways of understanding Jewish identity in the Anglophone world. In this sense, post-Holocaust literature can be read as a form of speculative narrative that navigates between historical trauma and the possibility of redefinition.

Ultimately, the study contributes to interdisciplinary discussions on speculative fiction, identity, and cultural memory, highlighting how literary narratives move between reality and imagination in order to articulate complex experiences of belonging and difference.

Stefania Schnakovszky is a PhD candidate at Ovidius University of Constanța, Romania, specializing in British and American Studies. Her research focuses on the literary and discursive representations of antisemitism and Jewish identity in the post-Holocaust era, with particular emphasis on trauma, diaspora, and intersectionality. She adopts an interdisciplinary approach, combining Critical Discourse Analysis with literary and cultural theory in order to examine how identity is constructed and negotiated across different contexts. Her work engages with both canonical and contemporary authors, exploring themes such as memory, marginalization, and resilience in Anglophone literature. She is particularly interested in feminist perspectives and the concept of double marginalization in relation to Jewish women writers. Stefania has presented her research at international conferences and is actively involved in academic projects related to language, culture, and identity. Her current work aims to contribute to ongoing discussions on the relationship between discourse, literature, and social representation.

Sen, Meheli. Rutgers University, U.S.A.

Pop-Tantra as Political Critique: Horror Media in Contemporary India

In conversation with the conference theme, this paper looks at the horror genre in India as an emergent site of political contestations. Since 2014, culture and media industries have undergone massive transformations. First, the meteoric rise of hardcore Hindu nationalism, and Prime Minister Narendra Modi's rise to national leadership has sent India's age-old commitment to "secularism" into complete disarray; this consolidation of a certain vision of a "Hindu Nation" has significant consequences for Muslims and other minorities. Second, the rapid spread of internet and digital technologies, especially social media, has enabled new ambits of discourse and participation, new imagined communities to emerge and congeal. Finally, the Covid-19 pandemic dealt a decisive blow to the political economy, as movie theatres remained shuttered for several months and the viewership of VOD platforms skyrocketed in tandem.

Sen argues that the imperative to construct a unified, Hindu nation undertaken by the ruling dispensation as being significantly challenged by the horror genre in the contemporary moment. Moreover, she suggests that regional horror texts provide an especially salubrious terrain for the expression of resistance, dissent, and dissidence against the hegemonic, totalitarian Hindu nation. A new investment in what she calls “pop Tantra” and “weird” deities is where these contestations are most saliently elaborated. She argues that a new kind of imagination buttresses several recent horror films, notably *Tumbbad* (Hindi, 2018), *Kumari* (Malayalam, 2022), *Kantara* (Kannada, 2022) and *Virupaksha* (Telugu, 2023), in marked variance from the generic cosmopolitan homogeneity of Hindi-language cinema. In addition to feature films, she looks at web-series such as *Parnashavarir Shaap* (Bengali, 2023) and *Bhog* (Bengali, 2025) which have traversed multiple media forms, from published stories to Youtube audio books, and finally to the televisual format attesting to their widespread popularity.

Meheli Sen is Associate Professor in the department of African, Middle Eastern, and South Asian Languages and Literatures, and the Cinema Studies program at Rutgers University. Her research area is post-independence Indian cinema, particularly Hindi and Bengali language films. She is especially interested in questions of gender, genre, modernity, globalization, and new media cultures. Her work has been published in journals such as *Cinema Journal*, *Framework: The Journal of Cinema and Media*, *LIT: Literature Interpretation Theory*, *South Asian Popular Culture*, among many others. She has co-edited an anthology titled *Figurations in Indian Film* (Palgrave-Macmillan, 2013). Sen’s book, *Haunting Bollywood: Gender, Genre and the Supernatural in Hindi Commercial Cinema* was published in 2017 by The University of Texas Press as well as Orient BlackSwan (South Asia). She is currently working on a book manuscript focusing on horror, digital media, and political cultures in contemporary South Asia.

Shah, Sonji. University of Cambridge, The United Kingdom
Speculative Geologies: Gendered Becoming in ‘Rock Jenny’

In the discipline of geology, narrative and scientific insight share a long history in which fictional narratives informed geologic perspectives and vice versa. Even though early geologists wrote and read romance and epic fictions that featured speculations about the Earth, modern natural science is meant to be neutral and dispassionate. In the Western philosophical tradition of logocentrism, geology studies the earth as material, fuelling extractive epistemologies and practices.

However, speculative fiction allows us to read for alternative ways of relating to rock and earth beyond extractive paradigms. In this paper, I explore how the story ‘Rock Jenny’ in Callum Angus’ short story collection *A Natural History of Transition* (2021) uses geology as metaphor for gendered becoming. Through expanding the boundaries of the story beyond consensus reality, the protagonist navigates the pressures and expectations of being a young mixed-race trans person by turning into rock. The deep time of geology is used to upend social expectations on the self and the body and instead reconfigures geology as a speculative approach to new sensory, temporal relations between self, others, and the Earth.

Sonji Shah is a writer and researcher. They are the recipient of the 2025 Curtis Brown Creative LGBTQIA+ Breakthrough Award. In their work as PhD researcher at the University of Cambridge, they research geologic speculative fiction. Recent publications include *Vector Magazine* (forthcoming), *Resurgence and Ecologist*, *Elemental: Water*, *The Rachel Carson Center online exhibition*, *Textured*, *Where the Leaves Fall*. Presented papers include 'Unearthing the archive: silver mining in contemporary speculative fiction' at the Eaton Conference on Speculative Fiction, UC Riverside and 'Lithospheric memory' at Alas de Tinta, University of Madrid.

Silva Martins, Marisa da. University of Aveiro, Portugal

Hunger for the Flesh: Fungi and Entomological Ecology in T. Kingfisher's Ecohorror Narratives

This presentation close-reads fungal, parasitic and entomological modes of invasion in two ecohorror narratives, T. Kingfisher's *What Moves the Dead* (2022) and *Wolf Worm* (2026), through the frameworks of transcorporeality and ecologies of entanglement. While recent scholarship has examined fungi as cultural metaphors of mycelial agency, or as posthuman forms of intelligence, this presentation expands the discussion by placing fungal decomposition in conjunction with parasitic and insectile modes of occupation and infestation. By contaminating human bodies and landscapes alike, these organisms expose the porosity of boundaries, demanding new understandings not solely about death and decay, but also humanity's position within the biotic community and processes of biological evolution. Rather than assigning fixed and specific characteristics to the lifeforms under scrutiny, the presentation identifies three overlapping modes of invasion (diffusive, extractive and manipulative), through which fungal and parasitic organisms unsettle bodily integrity. It examines how these invasive processes both disrupt the human/nonhuman distinction and undermine the life/death binary. Fungal decomposition emerges as a process of continuity instead of finality, while parasitism and insectile invasion foreground extraction by shifting the agency and behavioural patterns of their living hosts. These dynamics disclose bodies (particularly human ones) as porous sites of enmeshment and multispecies entanglement. Beyond framing nature as retaliatory, striking back at humanity as punishment for environmental disruption, these two ecohorror narratives materialize the unstable, entangled and co-dependent conditions of life in the Anthropocene. In parallel, T. Kingfisher's works confront readers with the darkest side of nature and lifeforms of biological alterity that profoundly unsettle humanist conceptions of the body.

Marisa da Silva Martins is a PhD student in Literary Studies, specializing in Children's Literature, and a trainee researcher at the Centre for Languages, Literatures and Cultures (CLLC) at University of Aveiro. She has completed her Master's degree in Modern Literatures and Cultures (English and North-American Studies) at NOVA School of Social Sciences and Humanities. She is a member of the Portuguese Association for Anglo-American Studies (APEAA). She was also a researcher at the Institute of Contemporary History/IN2PAST. She has presented papers in international conferences mainly on Children's Literature, Ecocriticism and the Blue Humanities. Apart from this, her research interests also include Speculative Fiction, Postcolonial Literature and

Reception Studies. Lately, her research interests have also started to engage with Ecohorror and Ecogothic, exploring ecological anxieties in contemporary fiction.

Soffer, Eyal. Anglia Ruskin University, The United Kingdom

Machiavellian Matriarchs: Reimagining *Virtù* and Cooperative Power in Feminist Speculative Fiction

Niccolò Machiavelli's political philosophy—especially his ideas of *virtù* (skill and strength) and *fortuna* (fate)—has long shaped power dynamics in science fiction and fantasy (SFF). While traditional interpretations center on patriarchal, isolated leadership models, my presentation argues that modern SFF by feminist authors reimagines Machiavellian principles to prioritize cooperative power and challenge gendered hierarchies. This argument directly addresses the theme of “Feminist Pasts, Feminist Futures in Speculative Fiction: Gender, Power, and Liberation.”

This presentation compares authors to show the shift from the male-centered politics of Isaac Asimov and Frank Herbert to the feminist perspectives of Lois McMaster Bujold and Kameron Hurley. Earlier texts tie *virtù* to masculine power, but Bujold and Hurley rethink these ideas, suggesting cooperative feminine approaches to political liberation. This presentation shows how feminist SFF challenges the lone, ruthless prince archetype. These narratives argue that true *virtù* for female characters appears through collaborative, networked leadership and dismantling of patriarchal power. These worlds act as laboratories for real-world political questions, revealing how female characters navigate and master Machiavellian systems without mirroring their misogyny. Soffer's research shows that feminist speculative fiction turns patriarchal political philosophy into a tool for empowerment. These texts show feminist futures where cooperative leadership is the ultimate political triumph, not a weakness.

Eyal Soffer holds a BA in Hebrew and English Literature and an MA in English Literature. His MA thesis was about the Machiavellian roots of Frank Herbert's *Dune*. He is in his seventh year as a PGR student at Anglia Ruskin University. His research focuses on the connection between Machiavelli and science fiction and fantasy series by Isaac Asimov, Frank Herbert, George Martin, Lois McMaster Bujold, and Kameron Hurley. Eyal Soffer was a high school teacher for many years and has been teaching EFL at Ben Gurion University of the Negev for the past 13 years. He also taught Introduction to Science Fiction at the same university.

Song, Nan. Lancaster University, The United Kingdom

Fast Approaching Peak Oil? Literary Engagements with Future Waste and Energy Systems

The global energy landscape is undergoing a moment in which energy majors are caught between their sustainable energy promises and the lure of returning to oil and gas production. To reduce oil dependency and secure stable energy use, another growing trend is to return to local community-based energy autonomy through renewable, decentralised, affordable energy resources. At a precarious time of looming oil crisis and energy transition, are energy majors still trustworthy for providing large-scale

sustainable energy? Is returning to local/small-scale communities the next normative ideal? What kinds of energy futures are possible to move past the energy status quo for a just transition?

This paper situates future energy and waste systems in Margaret Atwood's *The MaddAddam Trilogy*, a typical 'energy-waste' text. This paper argues that examining waste reuse and energy use in post-oil scenarios can be a productive method to represent, respond to, and challenge contemporary energy frameworks of sustainability and local resilience building—often portrayed as alternatives to oil dependency. Examining how waste's value changes during the peak oil crisis, this paper argues that reusing waste will not terminate the violence, inequality, and pollution of the oil age, but will risk perpetuating them in forms of garbage oil and 'petro-nostalgia' in the Pleeblands and 'compost-thinking' and local resilience building in God's Garden. Focusing on the post-apocalyptic multi-species community, this paper argues that envisioning a just energy transition involves learning from more-than-human waste-to-energy practices and attending to both human and more-than-human needs as much as possible for a degrowth future.

Nan Song is an AHRC-NWCDTP funded PhD student in English Literature at Lancaster University. Her PhD project, titled 'Reframing Waste: Imagining Waste Disposal in Contemporary Speculative Fiction', explores how speculative fiction combines waste with capitalist crises in the Anthropocene, while investigating intersections and tensions among the fields of speculative fiction, waste studies, and ecocriticism. Her research interests include waste studies, speculative fiction, ecocriticism, environmental humanities, energy humanities, and the Anthropocene.

Tamrin, Andi Febriana. University of Pécs, Hungary

Beyond the Alpha/Omega Binary: Subverting Gender and Power Dynamics in Speculative Fanfiction

Speculative fiction often serves as a medium to deconstruct the reality of social consensus. In the realm of fanfiction, the Omegaverse subgenre creates alternate biological realities—through the Alpha, Beta, and Omega caste systems—that allegorically reflect gender inequality and the suppression of bodily autonomy in the real world. Focusing on the Omegaverse fanfiction work of the *Heated Rivalry* fandom (Novel and TV series), *Breaking the Ice*, the study aims to analyze how biological worldbuilding is used as a tool of speculative fiction to subvert and challenge toxic hierarchical power dynamics. In this narrative, the world of professional ice hockey is represented as a hyper-masculine institution that systemically oppresses the Omegas, limiting their participation to only "soft" sports such as figure skating. Drawing on Judith Butler's analysis of Gender Performativity, this study examines the subversion of gender boundaries through two main characters. Shane Hollander, the legendary hockey captain nicknamed "The Golden Alpha", is an Omega who must continue to "show" the performance of Alpha's masculinity through an extreme routine of using hormone suppressants and fake pheromones so that his autonomy is not taken away. On the other hand, Ilya Rozanov, an Alpha who was traumatized by his father's patriarchal violence, dismantles toxic masculinity expectations by using his class privileges to

protect a young Omega hockey player named Daniel. The study's results show that the work succeeded in breaking the binary biological determinism. Shane's success as a top athlete proves that physical superiority and absolute leadership are not the biological monopoly of the Alpha. Furthermore, Ilya's character's evolution confirms that true strength does not lie in domination or structural violence, but in emotional vulnerability and in protecting the marginalized. In conclusion, Omegaverse fanfiction operates as a transgressive literary space that effectively dismantles hegemonic gender boundaries. By navigating sociocultural anxieties while offering hope, this narrative demonstrates that identities and power structures are not absolute but can always be reconstructed.

Andi Febriana Tamrin, an Indonesian student, is currently studying Literary and Cultural Studies at the University of Pécs in Hungary. Her research centers on fan studies and fanfiction, with a specific focus on the Omegaverse and its origins. She explores fanfiction as a form of transformational literature, particularly within the Slash Omegaverse subgenre across various fandoms. Her work covers topics such as identity negotiations, bodily autonomy, consent, and power dynamics, all portrayed through speculative narratives in transnational digital spaces.

Taveira de Almeida, Inês. Portuguese Catholic University, Portugal
Configuring Horror as Speculative Narrative: Fandom, Lore Construction and Transmedia World-Building in *Poppy Playtime*

This paper examines *Poppy Playtime* as a speculative horror narrative whose world is assembled through fragmented clues, fan interpretation, and cross-platform discourse. Drawing on Gerald Voorhees' concept of "discursive games" and "gamic discourse," the study argues that the game functions as a dynamic node in a broader network of convergent media texts where horror is collaboratively configured, circulated, negotiated, and contested across platforms. Its design, which includes scattered lore clues, cryptic VHS tapes, environmental storytelling through abandoned factory signage, and ARG-style external hints, deliberately withholds narrative closure, inviting players to act as configurative critics who assemble coherent backstories from partial and often contradictory information. This structural invitation becomes especially visible in online fan spaces. High-viewership YouTube lore-explainer videos, theory-crafting live streams, and Reddit threads debating plot coherence and franchise trajectory collectively produce narrative accounts while sustaining competing interpretations of key mysteries, such as the Prototype's motives, the "Hour of Joy" massacre, and Playtime Co.'s monstrous experiments. Integrating Voorhees' framework with Henry Jenkins' concept of participatory culture and Axel Bruns' notion of produsage, the paper conceptualises these practices as interpretive labour: a form of communicative work that materially extends, stabilises, and amplifies the speculative horror text beyond its playable boundaries. Employing qualitative, multi-sited discourse analysis of a purposive corpus of in-game sequences and high-engagement fan texts, including YouTube videos, live streams, and Reddit threads, the paper demonstrates how affect, particularly fear and fascination, emerges from interactions between game fragments and fan configuration. Ultimately, it argues that *Poppy Playtime*'s cultural resonance and horror impact derive as much from these distributed speculative discourses as from its formal design properties.

Inês Taveira de Almeida is a PhD candidate in Communication Sciences at Universidade Católica Portuguesa. Her research interests focus on transmedia storytelling, digital entertainment, fandom, and participatory culture. Inês T. de Almeida has over seven years of professional experience in social media and entertainment content creation, and is currently developing her doctoral work on transmedia entertainment, young adults, and fandom participation.

Tejero Marín, Ana. University of Salamanca, Spain

A home away from home: The afterlives of the Plantationocene in Rivers Solomon's *An Unkindness of Ghosts*

The Anthropocene refers to the current geological epoch, characterised by human modification of the planetary systems: as such, it appears to outline a purely earthbound phenomenon, limited to the confines of the Earth. Nonetheless, the Anthropocene cannot be only understood as a neutral description of the state of our planet: the Plantationocene as a reconceptualisation aims to highlight the socioeconomic origins of the phenomenon, rooted in racism, inequality and a desire for exploiting marginalised bodies and the Earth. As such, this ideology can be projected into outer space, understood as an infinite immensity ready for the expansion of capital. Stories that deal with generation ships prove relevant to analyse in this context. Generation ships are colossal vessels that carry humanity to another planet in the hopes of founding a new colony. The descriptor “generation” signals that the same people that depart from Earth are not the ones that will arrive at their new home: they will live their whole lives and reproduce inside the ship. This means that new societies will be conformed in the vessel, and these communities will usually replicate the ideologies that provoked their exile from planet Earth. In this respect, generation ships reinforce the connections to their original home instead of creating new modes of social ordering. In this presentation, I will explore how generation ship stories replicate the ideologies of the Anthropocene in a new context. As a case study, I will analyse *An Unkindness of Ghosts*, a story set in a vessel that replicates the structure of a plantation. In this manner, this novel shows how, without a radical rethinking of social hierarchies, humans are bound to reproduce the same damaging ideologies that made them leave Earth in the first place, and only through more ethical encounters between humans and with the nonhuman can they hope to establish a sustainable society.

Ana Tejero Marín is a PhD researcher at the University of Salamanca. Her thesis project focuses on counterimaginaries of the Anthropocene in contemporary science fiction and fantasy novels. She is a member of the research project RELY (Re-orienting Assemblage Theory in Contemporary Literature and Culture) and the research group iLAC (Intersections: Literature, Art and Culture in the Limen). Her main research interests are ecocriticism, contemporary science fiction and fantasy, and young adult literature.

Valle Sánchez, María Rosa. University of Salamanca, Spain

Motherhood Beyond Consensus Reality and Rage's Transformative Power in *Nightbitch* (2021)

This paper examines *Nightbitch* (2021) by Rachel Yoder as a work of feminist speculative fiction that destabilises consensus reality through the monstrous maternal body. Positioned at the intersection of horror and speculative fiction, the novel reconstructs the Gothic tradition of monstrous motherhood by portraying the maternal body as simultaneously abject and empowering. Drawing on Julia Kristeva's concept of abjection, Barbara Creed's formulation of the monstrous-feminine, and Adrienne Rich's distinction between motherhood as institution and experience, I argue that *Nightbitch* mobilises speculative horror to expose the suffocating cultural programming surrounding contemporary motherhood. The protagonist's metamorphosis into a dog operates as a speculative device that disrupts normative embodiment, foregrounding the maternal body as resistant to patriarchal containment. At the same time, it situates the text within feminist speculative traditions that imagine alternative modes of being beyond socially prescribed identities. Furthermore, the human-animal hybridity at the core of the narrative invites a reading through critical animal studies and posthumanist frameworks, suggesting new relational ontologies that challenge anthropocentric and gendered hierarchies. Hence, this paper contends that *Nightbitch* reclaims monstrosity not as failure or threat, but as a strategy of resistance. In doing so, it contributes to ongoing conversations in feminist speculative fiction about embodiment, agency, and the possibility of imagining maternal futures beyond the limits of consensus reality.

María Rosa Valle Sánchez is a PhD student in Advanced English Studies: Languages and Cultures in Contact at the University of Salamanca, her alma mater. Her research focuses on affect and gender studies, with special emphasis on female rage in contemporary anglophone literature, film, and popular culture. She collaborates with the ILAC research group as well as on various innovative teaching projects and coordinates the student project Voces Prohibidas, which amplifies marginalised female voices in literature and promotes critical engagement with gender narratives.

Viennas, Konstantinos. The National and Kapodistrian University of Athens, Greece On "Invisible Cities"

The present abstract entertains the premise that Italo Calvino's "Invisible Cities" is in fact a work of speculative fiction, not only because it contains fragments of existing cities in its imaginary ones, but also by posing ideas on the nature and the evolution of the city as a whole. Issues such as migration and citizens' cooperation and pitfalls like gentrification, ghettoisation, the abundance of environmental waste and the rise of political propaganda are all present in the narration of Marco Polo, who, just like every narrator, fuses what he has sensorially experienced in the cities with his own native city, hopes and dreams. Furthermore, through his discussions with the Emperor, the book becomes an open question on the nature and extent of power, debated between its indecisive and melancholic holder and his nimble envoy.

Thus, the connection with speculative fiction is double: On a concrete level, analysing the examples provided by the description of each city can open up a vast array of possibilities for connection with real places and events, while showcasing both opportunities for posthuman, futurist and just cities, where power is shared and the dangers of subjugation and environmental destruction are shunned. On a more abstract

note, Calvino's text provides a basis for the city that can be built if the people demand it, a vision for the future that works better for all urban populations and can transform the presently dysfunctional megalopolis into a place where thoughts and desires can be freely transmitted, allowing reality to be shaped by every living body; and it is precisely this duality that makes "Invisible Cities" timeless.

Konstantinos Viennas is a first year PhD student of Sociology of Law and a graduate of the LLM in Sociology of Law, Science and Technology at the National and Kapodistrian University of Athens. Although he holds a Bachelor in Law, he is moving away from law practice, focusing instead on the interplay of justice, space and power. In his endeavour, he has been inspired by scholars that use literary analysis (such as A. Philippopoulos – Mihalopoulos, M. Valverde and J. Butler) and being an avid reader and movie enthusiast has repeatedly been fascinated by the thin line between fiction and reality. His other academic interests include memory in post-conflict societies, bioethics, politics, modern sociology and philosophy of law.

Zarebska, Zuzanna. University of Aveiro, Portugal

The narratives of care and ageing in Charlotte Wood's *The Weekend* and *Stone Yard Devotional*: Of Women, Mice and Dogs

The Australian writer Charlotte Wood is the author of several novels and books of non-fiction such as *The Submerged Cathedral* (2004), *Animal People* (2011), *The Natural Way of Things* (2016), *The Weekend* (2020), *The Luminous Solution* (2021) and *Stone Yard Devotional* (2023) among other works, for which she has won many distinguished prizes.

The Weekend belongs to the genre of *Reifungsroman*, the novel of growth and a (re)establishment of meaningful relationships in later life. It is a story of vulnerability, mourning and freedom manifested relationally in a matrix of connections to other people and to the land that are not only lived but "felt". *The Weekend* tells the story of a lifelong friendship between four women. Jude, Wendy and Adel travel to celebrate Christmas in the Australian village of Bittoes in order to declutter a late friend's house before it is put up for sale after she has died of cancer. By doing so, they need to face the stories that have held them together in a "state of mutiny rather than stasis, a period of constant striving against the world, but also against oneself." (Collins *The Guardian*, 2020) The novel *Stone Yard Devotional* tells the story of a woman who leaves her established yet dissatisfying life to enter a religious community of nuns on the inhospitable planes of Monaro in Australia, where she explores the idea of being in relation to and for others as the most fundamental experience of being alive. The three visitations that the community lives connect their personal narratives to those of Australia's history as a nation and as an unconquered land.

This paper will examine the ethos of care that *The Weekend* and *Stone Yard Devotional* inspired by the work of Emmanuel Lévinas and Judith Butler. It will look at the genre of *Reifungsroman* and the philosophical concepts of responsibility towards oneself and others, of experience of grief, reverence and self-care and how these are negotiated through relational frameworks. Furthermore, I will analyze the incorporation of the motif of animal vs human life and their relationship to the environment. As such and

along the post-humanist argument, Wood's fiction will be read as one in which the boundaries between the non-human and human animal are not merely thematized but ethically and philosophically destabilized, positioning the former not as backdrop or symbol but as a co-constitutive presence that challenges the sovereignty of the latter. Of much interest to my intervention will also be the staging of the novel *The Weekend* at the Belvoir St Theatre in Sydney foregrounding the figure of the dog Finn highlighting its constitutive presence. As I will argue, healing and transformation are only possible in ethical relations that are non-anthropocentric, inseparable, simultaneous and based on care and co-responsibility.

Zuzanna Zarebska (PhD, Post-Doc) is an assistant professor at the Department of Languages and Cultures at the University of Aveiro. She was a visiting scholar at NUI Maynooth and UCD, Ireland working on Irish women's contemporary writing under Professor Margaret Kelleher. Her research interests include Irish, Australian and British literature and culture, cultural ageing, diaspora, feminisms, gender and identity studies. She is a member of *Rhome* and *Medical Humanities* projects and steers various programmes on ageing and the PI of the *Women and Ageing: Towards equality, dignity and improvement of life and well-being*. She is an associate editor of *Anglo Saxonica Journal* and a co-editor of a creative journal *ROAM: Representations of Home Creative Journal*.